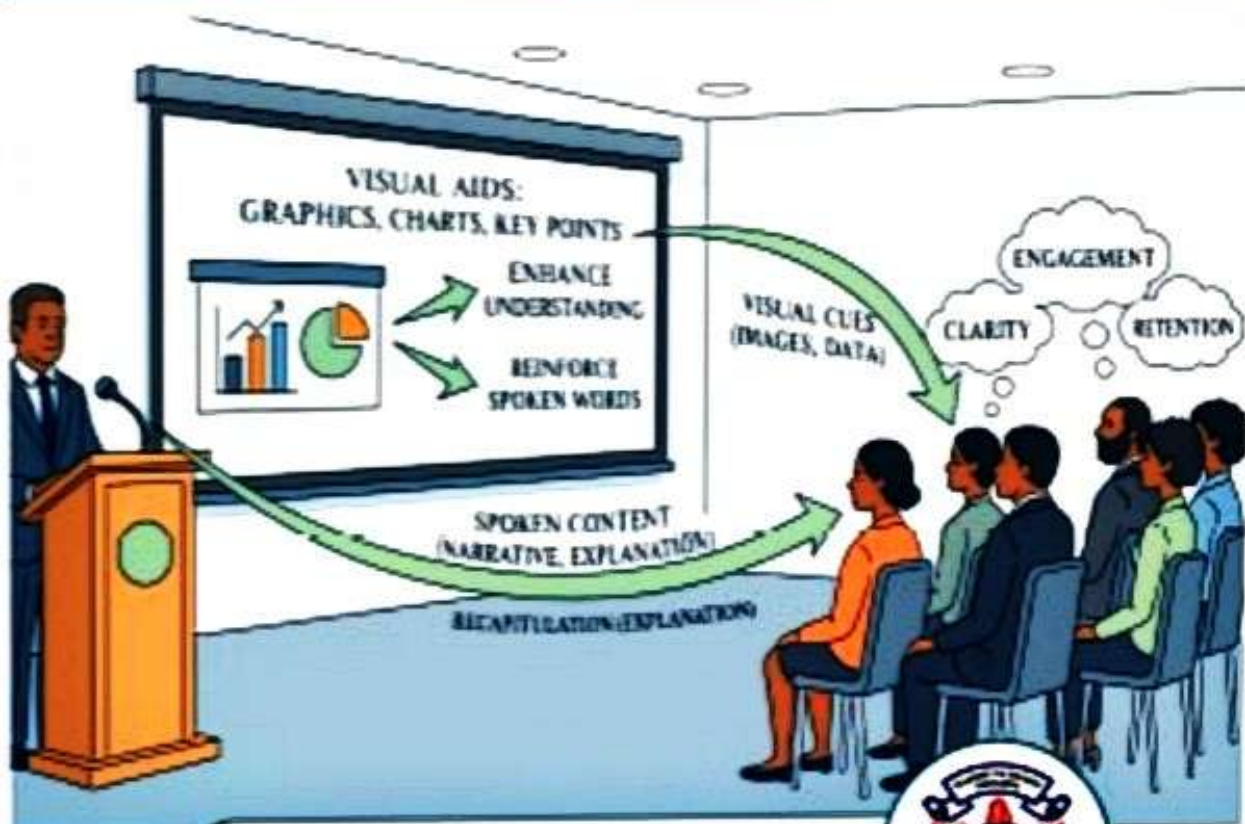


Academic Communication

for Advanced Secondary Schools

Student's Book

Form Six



Tanzania Institute of Education



Academic Communication

for Advanced Secondary Schools

Student's Book

Form Six

THE UNITED REPUBLIC OF TANZANIA
MINISTRY OF EDUCATION,
SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

Certificate of Approval

No. 2184

Academic Communication for Advanced Secondary
Schools Student's Book Form Six

Title of Publication:

Publisher: Tanzania Institute of Education

Author: Tanzania Institute of Education

ISBN: 978-9912-766-76-1

This book was approved by the Ministry of Education, Science
and Technology on 16th December 2025 as a Textbook for
Form Six students in Tanzania Secondary Schools as per
2023 Syllabus.


Dr. Lyabwene M. Mtahabwa
Commissioner for Education

Tanzania Institute of Education

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Published 2026

ISBN: 978-9912-766-76-1

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Table of Contents

Acknowledgements	v
Preface.....	vi
Chapter One	1
Writing with appropriate grammar and vocabulary	1
Revision questions	10
Chapter Two	12
Inferring meanings from various texts	12
Revision questions	22
Chapter Three	23
Mastering report writing skills	23
Revision questions	31
Chapter Four.....	32
Speaking with confidence and clarity	32
Revision questions	41
Chapter Five	42
Crafting clear and professional messages	42
Revision questions	48
Chapter Six.....	49
Writing project proposals and reports	49
Revision questions	56
Chapter Seven	57
Using ICT for research and referencing.....	57
Revision questions	66

Chapter Eight	67
Preparing and delivering academic presentations.....	67
Revision questions	78
Chapter Nine	79
Interpreting and using visual representations	79
Revision questions	86
Bibliography	88

Acknowledgements

The Tanzania Institute of Education (TIE) recognises and values the important contributions of all the organisations and individuals who participated in designing and developing this textbook. TIE wishes to thank teachers' colleges and secondary schools for their valuable support throughout the process of designing and developing this textbook. Besides, the following individuals are also highly acknowledged.

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TIE also appreciates the contributions of the secondary school teachers and students who participated in the trial phase of the manuscript of this textbook. Likewise, the Institute would like to thank the Ministry of Education, Science, and Technology for financing the writing and printing of this textbook.



Dr Aneth A. Komba

Director General

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Preface

This textbook, Academic Communication for Advanced Secondary Schools, Student's Book Form Six, is explicitly designed for Form Six students in the United Republic of Tanzania. The book has been prepared in accordance with the 2023 Academic Communication Syllabus for Advanced Secondary Education, Forms V–VI, issued by the Ministry of Education, Science, and Technology.

The book consists of nine chapters, namely Writing with appropriate grammar and vocabulary; Inferring meanings from various texts; Mastering report writing skills; Speaking with confidence and clarity; Crafting clear and professional messages; Writing project proposals and reports; Using ICT for research and referencing; Preparing and delivering academic presentations; and Interpreting and using visual representations. The book includes engaging activities, exercises, real-life examples, and interactive components to help you develop the four fundamental language skills: listening, speaking, reading, and writing. Additionally, the book will enhance your academic communication by developing skills commonly used in everyday interactions. You are required to prepare a portfolio documenting performed activities across different lessons to provide evidence of participation, understanding, and application of learned concepts.

Additional learning resources are available in the TIE e-library at <https://ol.tie.go.tz> or ol.tie.go.tz



Tanzania Institute of Education

Chapter One

Introduction

Effective writing requires more than simply putting words together; it requires clarity, accuracy, and a strong command of sentence structures. In this chapter, you will learn essential skills for constructing grammatically correct sentences. You will explore independent and dependent clauses and learn how to form simple, compound, and complex sentences. You will also develop accuracy by ensuring proper subject-verb agreement across various contexts. In addition, you will learn to use field-specific vocabulary to communicate ideas clearly in both academic and professional settings. The competencies developed will enable you to write with precision, coherence, and confidence.



Think

Correct sentence structures and precise vocabulary make your writing more transparent and effective

Constructing grammatically correct sentences

A sentence is a complete set of words that conveys meaning. A sentence may be composed of one or more clauses. A clause is a group of words that contains a subject and a predicate. In the sentence, “I don’t like the ocean because sharks scare me,” the words “I don’t like the ocean” make an independent clause, and the words “because sharks scare me” form the dependent clause.

An independent clause (or main clause) is a complete thought, and it can stand by itself to make sense. A dependent clause (or subordinate clause) is an incomplete thought, and it cannot stand by itself to make sense. You can spot a dependent clause by identifying a subordinating conjunction. The subordinating conjunction creates a dependent clause that relies on the rest of the sentence for meaning. The following are some examples of subordinating conjunctions.

- | | | | |
|-------------|------------|-----------------|--------------|
| i) after | iv) though | vii) although | x) since |
| ii) as | v) while | viii) because | xi) when |
| iii) before | vi) unless | ix) even though | xii) whereas |



Activity 1.1

Choose **one page** from a newspaper, textbook, or online article and do the following:

1. Identify **five sentences** from the text.
2. For each sentence you have identified:
 - (a) underline the **independent clause(s)**
 - (b) circle **dependent clause(s)** (if any)
3. Explain in two to three sentences how the clauses you have identified **affect** the meaning of each sentence.

Types of sentences

A sentence can serve various purposes, such as making a statement (e.g., "I'm studying."), giving a command (e.g., "Go away!"), expressing an exclamation (e.g., "I'm so excited!"), or asking a question (e.g., "What time is it?"). In a written text, sentences used to form paragraphs can be classified as simple, compound, or complex. Below is a description of each of these sentence types, along with relevant examples.

Simple sentences

A simple sentence consists of a single independent clause. The sentences below illustrate this structure:

- (i) Juma went to the party last night.
- (ii) Who is your best friend?
- (iii) She ate her lunch early.

In English, simple sentences commonly follow the Subject–Verb–Object (SVO) word order. This structural pattern is illustrated in the table below.

Subject	Verb	Object
Hamisi	will explore	the unusual object
Mwajuma	has broken	the cycle of poverty
My father and mother	are planning	a vacation
The bright girl	will guide	the students
That young boy	fixed	the computer
Reading novels	improves	language skills
What she presented	surprised	the committee
Some students	joined	the science club
My grandfather	sings	gospel songs
To succeed in life	requires	discipline and perseverance



Activity 1.2

Walk around your school environment and explore noticeboards, posters, classroom signs, and announcements. Then do the following:

1. Write down five simple real-life sentences that you find.
2. Rewrite each sentence using the Subject–Verb–Object (SVO) pattern, even if the original sentence does not follow this structure. Then practise saying the sentences aloud.
3. Compare your rewritten sentences with the original ones and identify the structural differences.
4. Construct one sentence for each of the following types of subjects: a pronoun, a noun, a gerund, a to-infinitive, and a wh-clause.
5. Read aloud each sentence you have written.

Some verbs can take two objects in sequence. The **object** that appears closer to the verb is known as the *indirect object*, while the one that appears farther from the verb is called the *direct object*. Semantically, the indirect object typically functions as the recipient, beneficiary, or addressee of the action. By contrast, the direct object denotes the entity that is acted upon or changes state. Sentences containing both an indirect and a direct object follow the structural pattern Subject – Verb – Indirect Object – Direct Object, as illustrated in the table below.

Subject	Verb	Indirect Object	Direct Object
I	gave	my sister	one million shillings
My parents	told	me	stories
We	have paid	him	some money
They	are asking	the guest speaker	some questions



Exercise 1.1

Rearrange the words to form correct sentences using the double-object structure.

Example: my mother / a birthday cake yesterday / me / baked

My mother baked me a birthday cake yesterday.

- (a) the woman / has bought / her daughter / some crayons
- (b) the police officer / the driver / his driving license / has just shown
- (c) the patient / gave / some medicine / the nurse
- (d) brought / me / a bunch of flowers last week / my uncle
- (e) the shopkeeper / the customer / paid / two hundred shillings
- (f) that brave girl / her uncle / built / a house
- (g) my mother / my sister's child / is teaching / English
- (h) has just written / a letter / the girl / me

Sometimes, an indirect object - namely, the recipient, beneficiary, or addressee of an action - is introduced by a preposition, resulting in the pattern Subject - Verb - Direct Object - Indirect Object. In such cases, the indirect object appears farther from the verb and is realised as a prepositional phrase, that is, a group of words headed by a preposition.

Subject	Verb	Direct Object	Indirect Object (Prepositional phrase)
My friend	has sent	a letter	to me
His parents	bought	a computer	for him
The woman	brought	some snacks	for her children



Exercise 1.2

Rewrite the following sentences by changing the word order from *Subject – Verb – Direct Object – Indirect Object* to *Subject – Verb – Indirect Object – Direct Object*.

Example: My brother showed his new wallet to me.

My brother showed me his new wallet.

- The postman brought a letter to her yesterday.
- The dog owner gives a bone to his dog every day.
- The students sent a present to their teacher.
- The gardener handed some flowers to me.
- My mother has prepared a cup of coffee for my father.

Compound sentences

A compound sentence consists of two independent clauses. These clauses are commonly joined by a coordinating conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so), which is usually preceded by a comma. The following are examples of compound sentences.

- She wanted to go home early today, so she finished her work quickly.
- I called you several times, yet you didn't answer.
- They wanted to travel to Zanzibar, but they didn't have enough money.



Activity 1.3

- Think of two events that happened to you today.
- Combine them into compound sentences using and, but, or, so, yet, and for.
- Write at least four such sentences and underline the coordinating conjunctions.
- Explain why each conjunction is appropriate for the meaning expressed.



Exercise 1.3

Make compound sentences by filling in the blanks with an appropriate coordinating conjunction provided in brackets.

- (a) Leave the house at once _____ I will call the police. (and, but, or)
- (b) I called her many times _____ she didn't answer the phone. (and, but, though)
- (c) He is intelligent _____ he is honest. (or, but, and)
- (d) He is old _____ he is active. (and, or, but)
- (e) The team worked late into the night, _____ they failed to meet the deadline. (yet, so, and).

Complex sentences

A complex sentence contains one independent clause and one or more dependent clauses. A subordinating conjunction connects the clauses in a complex sentence. Every complex sentence must include at least one subordinating conjunction. Common subordinating conjunctions used to form complex sentences include *although*, *because*, *when*, *if*, and *while*. The following are examples of complex sentences.

- (i) She went to class, although she was sick.
- (ii) When John arrived at work, he realised that he had forgotten his phone.
- (iii) While I enjoy classical music, I prefer rock and roll because I play the drums.



Activity 1.4

1. Observe something happening around you (a classroom activity, a school event, a weather change, a sports practice, etc.).
2. Write one complex sentence showing:
 - (a) time (when, before, after)
 - (b) cause (because, since)
 - (c) contrast (although, even though)
3. Circle the subordinating conjunction in each sentence you have composed.



Exercise 1.4

1. Join each of the following pairs of clauses using a coordinating conjunction to form one complex sentence. Use the coordinating conjunctions provided in brackets.

Example

My dog waited at the door for us. We got home (until)

My dog waited at the door for us until we got home.

- (a) We do all our homework. We won't be allowed to play (unless).
- (b) My sister gets in trouble. My father makes her weed the garden (whenever).
- (c) Mary was sick. She insisted on attending the class (although).
- (d) I had to go to the dentist. My back tooth started to hurt (because).
- (e) I finished my project. I asked my mother to check it for mistakes (when).

2. Complete the following complex sentences by filling in the blanks with appropriate subordinating conjunctions provided in the box.

before	since	so that	unless	when
whenever	wherever	whether	while	

- (a) _____ we had a hard time finding our way home, we consulted the neighbourhood map.
- (b) _____ the bus reached the final stop, everyone got off.
- (c) _____ you study hard, it will be difficult for you to pass your exams.
- (d) The driver was fined _____ he dropped the passenger at a wrong station.
- (e) The students were asked _____ they were happy to attend classes over the weekend.

Subject-verb agreement

For a sentence to be regarded as grammatically correct, the subject and the verb of the sentence must agree. A singular subject requires a singular verb, and a plural subject needs a plural verb. Thus, the subject and its verb are said to agree in number. This fundamental rule is crucial for sentence coherence and clarity.

In the present tense, the base form of a verb is used with all plural subjects and the pronouns I and you. For singular subjects other than I and you, -s or -es is usually added to the base form of the verb. The following examples show subject-verb agreement in the present tense.

Singular	Plural
I walk	We walk
You walk	You walk
He/she/it walks	They walk

The irregular verbs *be*, *have*, and *do* must agree with the subject, whether used as main verbs or helping verbs.

Examples

1. I **am** a botanist. He **is** a botanist. They **are** botanists. (main verbs)
2. She **is** working. You **are** studying. (helping verbs)
3. I **have** a job. She **has** a car. (main verbs)
4. He **has** planted a tree. They **have** planted trees. (helping verbs)
5. He **does** well. They **do** the job. (main verbs)
6. It **does** sound good. We **do** work hard. (helping verbs)

Basic rules of subject-verb agreement

- Rule 1:** Singular subjects take singular verbs. Example: The **dog barks** at strangers. Plural subjects take plural verbs. Example: **Dogs bark** at strangers.
- Rule 2:** Subjects joined by 'and' are usually plural and take a plural verb. Example: **The teacher and the student discuss** the assignment. If the compound subject refers to a single entity, it takes a singular verb. Example: **Rice and beans is** a common meal in many countries.
- Rule 3:** When subjects are joined by 'or' or 'nor', the verb agrees with the subject closest to it. Example: Neither the teacher **nor the students are prepared**. Example: Either the teacher or **the student is responsible**.
- Rule 4:** Singular indefinite pronouns take singular verbs (each, everyone, someone, etc.). Example: **Everyone loves** a good story. Some indefinite pronouns can be singular or plural depending on the context (all, some, none, etc.). Example: **All the cake is** gone. **All the cookies are** gone.
- Rule 5:** Collective nouns (team, group, class, etc.) may take singular or plural verbs depending on whether the group is acting as a unit or as individuals. Example: **The team wins** the match / **The team are** arguing among themselves.



Activity 1.5

1. Collect **five** sentences from any source, such as social media posts, schoolbooks, signboards, or announcements.
2. Check **each** sentence for subject-verb agreement.
3. If **any** sentence has an error, rewrite it correctly.

For each correction, explain which rule applies (e.g., singular or plural subjects, collective nouns, or indefinite pronouns).



Exercise 1.2

1. Choose the correct verb form to complete each sentence.
 - (a) The dog ____ (bark/barks) loudly every night.
 - (b) The students ____ (is/are) writing their essays.
 - (c) The teacher and the librarian ____ (discuss/discusses) the new books.
 - (d) Rice and beans ____ (is/are) served in the school cafeteria.
 - (e) Neither the principal nor the teachers ____ (is/are) attending the workshop.

2. Each of the following sentences contains a subject-verb agreement mistake. Correct them.
 - (a) The cat and the dog plays in the garden.
 - (b) Neither the teacher nor the students is ready for the lesson.
 - (c) Each of the participants have completed the survey.
 - (d) The visitor we have been waiting for have just arrived.
 - (e) All the mangoes is finished.
3. Construct five sentences with correct subject-verb agreement using the following types of subjects:
 - (a) Singular and plural subjects
 - (b) Compound subjects
 - (c) Subjects joined by "or" or "nor"
 - (d) Indefinite pronouns
 - (e) Collective nouns

Advanced rules of subject-verb agreement

- Rule 1:** Titles, names, and plural forms: Titles of books, movies, and other works take a singular verb. Example: "**The Man of the People**" is a popular novel. Words that are plural in form but singular in meaning take a singular verb. Example: **Mathematics is a challenging subject.**
- Rule 2:** Inverted sentences: In sentences where the subject follows the verb, ensure proper agreement. Example: **There is a book** on the table / **There are many books** on the table.
- Rule 3:** Amounts and quantities: Expressions of amount or quantity take a singular verb when considered as a unit. Example: **Five hundred is** too much to pay for a cup of tea.
- Rule 4:** Relative clauses: In relative clauses (a part of a sentence that describes a noun, and usually begins with words like 'who', 'which' or 'that'), the verb agrees with the antecedent (the noun the clause refers to). Example: **She is one** of the students **who have** passed the exam.
- Rule 5:** Uncountable nouns: Uncountable nouns take singular verbs. Example: **The information is** reliable.



Activity 1.6

1. Find examples of the following from newspapers, textbooks, or online articles:
 - (a) a sentence with a title requiring a singular verb
 - (b) a sentence starting with *There is/There are*
 - (c) a sentence expressing an amount or measurement
 - (d) a sentence with a relative clause (*who, that, which*)
 - (e) a sentence with an uncountable noun

2. Copy them and explain why the verb form is correct.
3. Rewrite each sentence, changing the subject, and adjust the verb accordingly.



Exercise 1.6

1. Each of the following sentences has a subject-verb agreement error. Identify the error and rewrite the sentence correctly.
 - (a) The United Nations are working hard to resolve the conflict.
 - (b) There is many reasons why students fail exams.
 - (c) Fifty dollars are too much for this old dictionary.
 - (d) She is one of the scientists who have discovered new species.
 - (e) The equipment in the lab are expensive.
2. Construct one sentence with correct subject-verb agreement using each of the following types of subjects:
 - (a) Amounts and quantities
 - (b) Uncountable noun
 - (c) Relative clause

Using field-specific vocabulary in communication

Every field of study has its own specialised words, known as *field-specific vocabulary* or *technical terms*. These are words that people in a particular area use to talk about ideas, tools, or activities related to that field. For example, in science, we often encounter terms such as *experiment*, *solution*, and *energy*. In commerce, we use terms such as *profit*, *goods*, and *customers*. Conversely, we discuss *harvest*, *irrigation*, *fertiliser*, and related terms in agriculture. Learning and using these words correctly helps us to communicate clearly and confidently in both speaking and writing. The following table shows examples of field-specific vocabulary.

Field	Common words	Example sentence
Science	experiment, energy, evaporation, temperature, solution	The experiment showed that heat changes water into steam.
Commerce	goods, profit, customer, market, supply, demand	The shopkeeper increased the price because demand was high.
Agriculture	harvest, fertiliser, seedling, irrigation, yield	Farmers use irrigation to water their crops during dry seasons.
Health	disease, treatment, diagnosis, patient, nutrition	The physician advised the patient to eat a nutritious diet.
Technology	computer, software, database, internet, application	Students use computer applications to do their assignments.



Activity 1.7

1. Choose one field (science, commerce, technology, agriculture, or health).
2. Find a short YouTube video, news item, or textbook paragraph related to the field you chose in 1.
3. Identify eight to ten field-specific words used in the content.
4. Create a mini glossary by writing:
 - (a) the word
 - (b) its field
 - (c) a simple definition
 an example sentence of your own



Revision questions

1. Rearrange the following words in correct order to make complete simple sentences:
 - (a) some Mathematics problems/ the students / have solved
 - (b) newspapers / every day / my boss / reads
 - (c) the cook / some chocolate cakes / has made
 - (d) he / his brother / the secret / has never told
 - (e) has ever given / any help / the blind woman / no one in the street
2. Rewrite the following sentences by changing the word order from Subject – Verb – Direct Object – Indirect Object to Subject – Verb – Indirect Object – Direct Object:
 - (a) She found a seat in the concert for me last Sunday.
 - (b) Betty has painted a beautiful picture for her best friend.
 - (c) We bought a pair of gloves for our uncle on his birthday.
 - (d) The tailor made a new dress for the princess.
 - (e) Judy baked some chocolate cookies for me.
3. Make compound sentences by filling in the blanks with an appropriate coordinating conjunction provided in brackets.
 - (a) You may _____ spend the night here or go home. (neither, either, nor)
 - (b) I reached the counter and took my purse out _____ there was no money in it. (and, but, or)
 - (c) The way may be long, and we may feel tired _____ we will not give up hope. (and, but, and, also)
 - (d) We took part in the competition _____ we did not win any prize. (and, but, or)
 - (e) Our servant is slow _____ he is honest and dependable. (and, but, so)
4. Choose the correct verb form to complete each sentence.

- (a) Either the librarian or the student _____ (is/are) responsible for returning the books.
- (b) Everyone _____ (enjoy/enjoys) participating in the debate competition.
- (c) Some of the information _____ (is/are) missing in this report.
- (d) Some of the students _____ (has/have) already submitted their assignments.
- (e) The class _____ (has/have) chosen its representative.
5. Read the passage below and underline all field-specific words. Then, explain which field this passage belongs to? What technical words can you find?
- Modern farmers use machines such as tractors and power tillers to prepare their land for planting. They also apply fertiliser to increase the yield. After harvesting, some farmers sell their produce directly to the market to earn income.*
6. Write a short paragraph about one of the following topics. Use appropriate field-specific vocabulary in your paragraph.
- (a) How technology helps students learn better
- (b) How farmers prepare their land before planting
- (c) Why good customer service is important in business

Inferring meanings from various texts

Introduction

Clear and accurate communication requires more than simply using words. It demands clarity, precision, and an understanding of how language conveys both explicit and implicit meanings. In this chapter, you will strengthen your communication skills by learning how to use field-specific vocabulary accurately across different disciplines. You will also explore how words can carry deeper meanings through denotation, connotation, tone, and attitude. In addition, you will examine figurative language, draw inferences from context, and interpret implicit expressions commonly found in academic texts. The competencies developed will help you communicate more confidently, analyse information more critically, and express ideas with greater depth and effectiveness.



Think

Word choice matters in communication

Interpreting the implied meanings of words and sentences

In communication, words and sentences often carry meanings that go beyond their literal definitions. Understanding these implied meanings helps one to read critically, interpret texts accurately, and express ideas more effectively. This involves distinguishing between denotation and connotation, recognising tone and attitude, identifying figurative language, drawing inferences from context, and interpreting implicit messages in academic texts. Learning to interpret implied meanings not only strengthens comprehension skills but also enables one to analyse, question, and communicate with clarity in both academic and everyday settings.



Activity 2.1

1. Your teacher assigned you to prepare for a debate competition. During practice, he or she reviewed your group's presentation and commented as follows:

Teacher: Your argument is quite strong, but you might want to polish it a little.

Group Leader: So, is it good, or not good enough?"

Teacher: Well, if you're comfortable presenting it the way it is, then go ahead.

[The group members look at each other, unsure whether the teacher approves of their work or advises them to revise it.]

2. Identify where the teacher's comments become unclear because you must decide what is *directly said* and what is *suggested*.



Exercise 2.1

Read the following passage and answer the questions that follow.

"I see you finally arrived," the teacher said as Amina walked into the classroom. Amina smiled, unsure whether the teacher was genuinely pleased to see her or was quietly disappointed about her lateness. The other students looked up, some thinking the teacher was joking, while others sensed an annoyed tone. Amina sat down, wondering what the teacher truly meant."

- (a) What is the literal meaning of the teacher's statement, "I see you finally arrived"?
- (b) What different implied meanings could the teacher be suggesting?
- (c) What words or clues in the passage help you guess the teacher's tone?
- (d) With examples from the text, explain why the students interpret the message differently.
- (e) What attitude do you think the teacher had? Give a reason for your answer.
- (f) How can context and tone change the meaning of the same sentence in communication?

Understanding denotative and connotative meanings

Denotation refers to the literal or primary meaning of a word as it is given in the dictionary. It is the type of meaning that corresponds to an intellectually objective level of interpretation. It is therefore based on distinctive semantic features of an entity. For example, the distinctive semantic features of 'girl' are listed as +human, +young, +female. Thus, the word 'girl' denotes a young female human.

Connotation relates to an idea or feeling that a word invokes beyond its primary meaning. It is the type of meaning that arises out of emotional associations of a word. The associations may be personal or communal. Depending on our experience of the world, certain words have positive connotations, while others have negative ones. Yet, others invoke a neutral connotation. For example, the connotation of the word 'home' might include warmth, security and comfort. Similarly, the word 'mother' connotes care, love, and respect. Moreover, the word 'snake' denotes a reptile, but it may connote danger or betrayal depending on the context. These examples show that understanding connotation helps us interpret not only the literal meaning of words but also the emotions and attitudes they express in communication. The following table summarises the differences between denotation and connotation:

Denotation	Connotation
Refers to the literal or dictionary definition of a word	Involves the emotional or cultural associations linked to a word beyond its literal meaning
Provides the straightforward, objective meaning of a word	Carries subjective and nuanced interpretations, influenced by personal experiences and societal context
Often used in technical or scientific contexts	Used in persuasive writing, advertising, and poetry
Provide the explicit, surface-level meaning of words	Offers the implicit, suggestive, or symbolic meanings of words



Activity 2.2

Use a dictionary to find the denotative meaning of the following words. Then provide the connotative meaning of each word based on your societal background and personal experience.

S/N	Word/phrase	Denotative meaning	Connotative meaning
1.	Hare		
2.	Lice		
3.	Man		
4.	Village		
5.	Woman		



Exercise 2.2

In one paragraph, explain how the confusion between literal and implied meanings can affect communication in real-life situations (school, home, workplace, online).

Recognising the tone and attitude of a speaker or writer

Understanding a speaker's or writer's tone is an important skill for effective communication. Tone refers to the attitudes that words convey. In writing, tone is conveyed through word choice, punctuation, and sentence structure; in speaking, it can be conveyed through verbal, audio, and visual cues, such as facial expressions, vocal pitch, and body language. All of these can help communicate your attitude toward a topic. The words someone chooses, along with how they are expressed, can reveal feelings, opinions, or emotions that are not always stated directly. For example, the sentence "That's an interesting idea" could show genuine interest or polite doubt, depending on the speaker's tone or context. Learning to recognise these cues can help one better interpret meaning and respond appropriately in different situations. Can you tell the tone/attitude of the following utterances?

“I can’t believe you did that!”

“Wow, that’s amazing!”

“Really?”

“Really!”

“I told you a thousand times...”

The utterance “I can’t believe you did that!” conveys the tone/attitude of either shock, disapproval, or anger, depending on emphasis. The utterance “Wow, that’s amazing!” depicts either excitement or admiration. The expression “Really?” can indicate doubt or sarcasm, while “Really!” shows surprise or enthusiasm. The utterance “I told you a thousand times...” shows frustration or annoyance.

It is important to consider what you want your audience to feel when deciding on your writing’s tone. The following table presents the common types of tone and their example sentences.

Type of tone	Description	Example
Authoritative	It is direct, confident, and deliberate with word choice. It is easy to understand.	Submit your homework to my office by Tuesday this week.
Edgy	It is cool and experimental. It does not try to impress anyone.	Homework by Tuesday? Thanks.
Casual	It is informal, personable, and conversational. It sounds like how you would talk to a friend.	Hey, can I get the homework by Tuesday?
Confident	It resembles an authoritative tone, but it does not necessarily come from a higher rank.	Submit the homework by this Tuesday. I’ll mark and provide feedback by the end of the week.
Inspirational	It is encouraging, reassuring, and passionate. It urges its audience to act through uplifting word choice instead of demands.	Please submit the homework to me by Tuesday this week.
Friendly	This tone is clear, relatable, and positive.	Hi folks! It would be great if you could submit the homework by Tuesday this week.
Formal	It is clear, thorough and respectful. It maintains proper writing and grammar while avoiding slang and exclamation points.	Good morning. Please submit the homework that I gave you by Tuesday this week.

Type of tone	Description	Example
Optimistic	Like the inspirational tone, the optimistic style is hopeful and positive. It depicts looking forward to the future.	Thank you all for attending my class. I'll be happy to receive your homework by Tuesday this week.
Informative	An informative tone is instructive. It imparts wisdom and gets to the point.	Please have your homework by Tuesday this week. I need enough time to mark them.
Questioning	The speaker/writer is often unsure and thus concludes with a question even when the utterance is a statement rather than a question. It is the opposite of a confident tone.	Not sure if we have enough time, but are you happy to submit the homework by Tuesday this week?
Joyful	It is cheerful and focused on positive emotions. It elicits warm, fuzzy feelings.	Hope you are having fun! When you get the chance, please submit the homework by Tuesday. I'll be waiting in my office.



Exercise 2.3

The following statement is in an authoritative tone: "Close all doors and windows of the building before 6 p.m." Change it to the following types of tone:

- Casual
- Inspirational
- Friendly
- Informative
- Joyful



Activity 2.3

Read the following short texts carefully. Each text represents a different type of writing: an advertisement, a news report, a poem excerpt, and an email. Identify the tone of each text (for example: formal, humorous, critical, respectful, persuasive, etc.) and explain your choice by referring to specific words or expressions that show the writer's attitude.

Text 1: Advertisement

"BrightSmile Toothpaste — because your smile deserves to shine! Say goodbye to dull, yellow teeth and hello to fresh confidence. Try BrightSmile today and show the world your brightest you!"

Questions

- What emotions does this advertisement create in the reader?
- Which words show how the advertiser feels about the product?

3. What is the tone of this text?
4. What is the writer's attitude toward the product and the audience?

Text 2: News report

"Heavy rainfall over the past week has caused severe flooding in several low-lying areas of Morogoro. Dozens of families have been displaced, and local authorities are urging residents to move to higher ground. Emergency teams are working to provide shelter and food to those affected."

Questions

1. How does the writer sound: emotional, serious, or humorous?
2. What is the writer's purpose in this report?
3. Which words or phrases suggest the tone?

Text 3: Poem excerpt

*The clock ticks on, unmoved by dreams,
While tired hands reach for the dawn.
Yet still we rise, through hopes and schemes,
To greet a day reborn.*

Questions

1. What feelings or moods does the poet create?
2. Which words reveal the poet's attitude toward life or time?
3. How would you describe the tone of this poem?

Text 4: Email

*Dear Class Monitor,
I understand that some students were unhappy with the schedule change. However, the adjustment was necessary to ensure that every subject gets equal time before exams. I appreciate your understanding and cooperation.
Best regards,
Ms. Kamara*

Questions

1. What kind of relationship exists between the sender and the recipient?
2. How does the sender sound: polite, annoyed, apologetic, or formal?
3. What is the writer's attitude toward the issue?

After reading all four texts:

4. Label each text with an appropriate tone.
5. Describe the writer's attitude in one or two sentences.
6. Explain how word choice and sentence style help you identify both the tone and the attitude.



Activity 2.4

Compose short texts with an appropriate tone based on the following contexts:

- One of your examinations did not go well.
- Your favourite team has won the tournament. Write a message to your friend to express your joy and excitement.

Identifying figurative language: Meanings beyond the literal

In academic communication and everyday speech, people often use *figurative language* to express ideas more creatively or powerfully. Figurative language goes beyond the literal meaning of words to suggest deeper or hidden meanings. Instead of stating something directly, writers and speakers use figures of speech to paint vivid pictures, evoke emotions, or make complex ideas easier to understand. There are four common types of figurative language: metaphor, simile, irony, and sarcasm.



Activity 2.5

- Use reliable online or offline sources to research the four common types of figurative language mentioned in this section.
- Read each explanation provided in the table below. Then, write the correct type of figurative language in the second column.

Explanation	Type of Figurative language
It is a direct comparison between two unlike things without using words <i>like</i> or <i>as</i> . It shows that one thing <i>is</i> another to highlight a shared quality. For example, in the sentence " <i>Time is a thief</i> ," time does not literally steal, but the metaphor suggests that time quickly takes away moments from our lives. Similarly, when we say, " <i>He kicked the bucket</i> ," it does not mean he physically kicked a bucket. Instead, the phrase <i>implies death</i> .	
It compares two different things but uses words <i>like</i> or <i>as</i> . For example, " <i>Her smile was as bright as the sun</i> " means that her smile was very cheerful or warm, not that it literally shone like the sun. Both metaphors and similes make descriptions more vivid and help readers or listeners imagine the message more clearly.	
It involves saying one thing while meaning the opposite, often to create humour or emphasise a point. For instance, if someone steps outside during a heavy rainstorm and says, " <i>What a lovely day!</i> " the statement is ironic because the weather is actually unpleasant. Irony makes communication more interesting and can reveal a writer's or speaker's attitude indirectly.	

Explanation	Type of Figurative language
It is a sharper form of irony used to mock or express strong disapproval. For example, when a student who arrives late to class hears the teacher say, "Nice of you to join us on time," the teacher doesn't mean it literally; but he or she uses sarcasm to point out the lateness.	

Understanding figurative language helps people interpret texts more deeply. It lets people look beyond surface meanings and recognise emotions, attitudes, and intentions in writing and speech. By mastering figurative devices such as metaphor, simile, irony, and sarcasm, one can make one's communication more expressive and effective.



Exercise 2.4

Read the following passage and answer the questions that follow.

The river crawls lazily through the valley, a tired snake searching for memories of rain. It whispers like an old friend who has seen better days, telling secrets to the stones beneath its skin. Once, it was a proud king, roaring across the land and giving life to every root and blade of grass. Now, it lies like a forgotten road, cracked and dusty, pretending to be asleep. The villagers, who once praised it as their "eternal blessing," now laugh bitterly: what a generous river, they say, as they carry buckets of muddy water home. Yet, a child still tosses a pebble into the shallow stream, smiling as if to say, "You will rise again." The irony flows with the current: even when nature fades, hope refuses to drown.

Questions

- What figures of speech are used in the passage?
- What is the meaning of each figure of speech in (i)?
- What is the tone and attitude of the speaker?
- How does the tone and attitude of the speaker help you understand the meaning of the text?



Activity 2.6

Write a text employing different figures of speech and show how they are used to convey intended meanings.

Drawing inferences from context

Sometimes writers or speakers do not say exactly what they mean, but they give hints through their words, tone, or situation. Learning to use context clues helps you figure out what is *implied* rather than directly stated. For example, if a teacher says, "You really tried," after reading a student's essay, the words sound encouraging, but the implied meaning might be

that the essay wasn't very good. By paying attention to the situation, tone, and choice of words, you can better understand hidden meanings and interpret messages more accurately, a valuable skill in both reading and everyday communication.



Exercise 2.5

- Read each short statement and explain what is implied (not directly said).
 - A friend says, "Wow, you're early today," when you arrive five minutes late.
 - A teacher says, "That's an interesting answer," after a student gives a wrong response.
 - A parent says, "I see your room is... creative," when the room is messy.
- What do the above statements really mean? Explain your reasoning using context clues.
- Read the dialogue below and answer the questions that follow.
Student: I finished my project last night.
Teacher: Oh, you finally finished it?
 - What does the teacher's tone suggest?
 - What is the implied attitude or meaning behind the teacher's response?
 - Which word gives the strongest clue?
- Think of a real-life situation (home, school, or social media) where someone's tone or words implied something different from what he or she said. Describe the problem and explain what helped you infer the true meaning.



Activity 2.7

Write two short situations (2–3 sentences each) where someone says something that *implies* more than what is directly stated.

Interpreting implicit sentences in academic texts

In academic and professional writing, authors often use hedging, cautious language, or understatement to express ideas carefully and avoid sounding too certain when evidence is limited. This technique helps writers sound reasonable, respectful, and open to other viewpoints. For example, instead of saying "Diet directly improves performance", a writer might say, "The evidence suggests a possible connection between diet and performance." Such wording implies that there may be a link, but it is not fully proven. When reading or writing academic texts, one should learn to notice and use subtle expressions like *may*, *might*, *appears to*, or *suggests that* to communicate ideas responsibly and thoughtfully.

**Exercise 2.6**

- Read the following sentences and underline the words or phrases that show uncertainty or caution. Then, explain what the author really means (the implied message).
 - The findings might indicate a link between sleep and learning outcomes.
 - It appears that students who study in groups perform better.
 - The research suggests that motivation plays a role in success.
 - These results may not fully represent the entire population.
- Rewrite the following direct statements to make them more cautious and academic.
 - Online learning improves student performance.
 - Teachers' attitudes determine students' success.
 - Technology causes distraction in classrooms.
 - Physical exercise increases memory power.
- Compare each pair of sentences below. Tick (✓) the one that sounds more academic and explain why.
 - The drug cures the disease.
 - The drug *may help reduce* the symptoms of the disease.
 - Social media *appears to* influence young people's communication habits.
 - Social media *influences* young people's communication habits.

**Activity 2.8**

Read the following paragraph and answer the questions that follow.

Recent studies suggest that using visuals in learning might enhance students' memory retention. However, it is not certain whether this applies to all learners or only specific age groups. Some researchers indicate that visual aids could be particularly beneficial for younger learners. It is also possible that individual learning styles play a significant role in determining how effective visuals are. While visuals appear to support comprehension in many situations, there is still limited evidence on how consistently they help across different subjects. Therefore, more research may be needed to understand the conditions under which visuals truly improve learning outcomes.

- Identify the hedging expressions used.
- What is the author's attitude toward the claim?
- Rewrite the paragraph in a more direct tone. How does it change the meaning or tone?

**Revision questions**

1. Discuss how failure to distinguish between denotation and connotation can lead to misinterpretation.
2. Drawing examples from academic or real-life communication, discuss how the ability to infer implied meanings improves critical reading and effective communication.
3. Explain with examples how figurative language, irony, and sarcasm communicate hidden meanings in one of the following contexts (social media, songs, or everyday conversations).
4. Misunderstandings often happen not because of the words used, but because listeners ignore tone, context, and intention. Prepare a PowerPoint presentation to sensitise your fellow students to the importance of paying attention to tone, context, and intention for effective listening.
5. Based on the competence you have developed in this chapter, propose a set of guidelines to be used to infer meaning from an academic. Explain why each guideline is important.

Mastering report writing skills

Introduction

Report writing is an essential part of academic life. It plays a significant role in maintaining records and resolving reported problems. In this chapter, you will learn the key features of a good report, the structure of a report, the steps involved in writing a report, the appropriate language and style to use, as well as referencing and citations. The competencies developed will help you write effective reports for academic, business, and community or social purposes.

Think

The reasons people write reports

Concept of a report

A report is a structured written composition intended to present information about an event or situation to a specific audience. It is written after a systematic investigation, observation, or experience. Understanding how to write a report is important because reports are required in our careers and daily lives. In schools, teachers often write reports on various issues related to students' academic journey. For example, they assess students and then write reports on their performance. Police officers respond to accident scenes, investigate crimes and provide reports. Similarly, businesspeople, office staff, and government workers write reports on issues such as work progress, monthly activities, and meeting resolutions.

Purposes and types of reports

Reports serve various purposes such as keeping records, informing, drawing conclusions, offering solutions or analysing problems. Reports can be categorised into two major types: formal and informal. However, informal reports are usually rare in professional or institutional settings. When they occur, they are often delivered orally. Most reports tend to be formal, addressing complex topics that require substantial background, research, and evidence. They are conventionally organised into formal headings to keep the reader on track. Formal reports can be prepared routinely or on-demand.

Routine formal reports include progress reports, annual sales activity reports, quarterly financial reports, inspection reports, annual confidential employee reports, and inventory reports. Conversely, on-demand formal reports are written only when needed, specifically

in response to a particular scenario. These include informational reports and interpretive reports. The following diagram illustrates the types of reports. A description of these types is provided after the illustration.

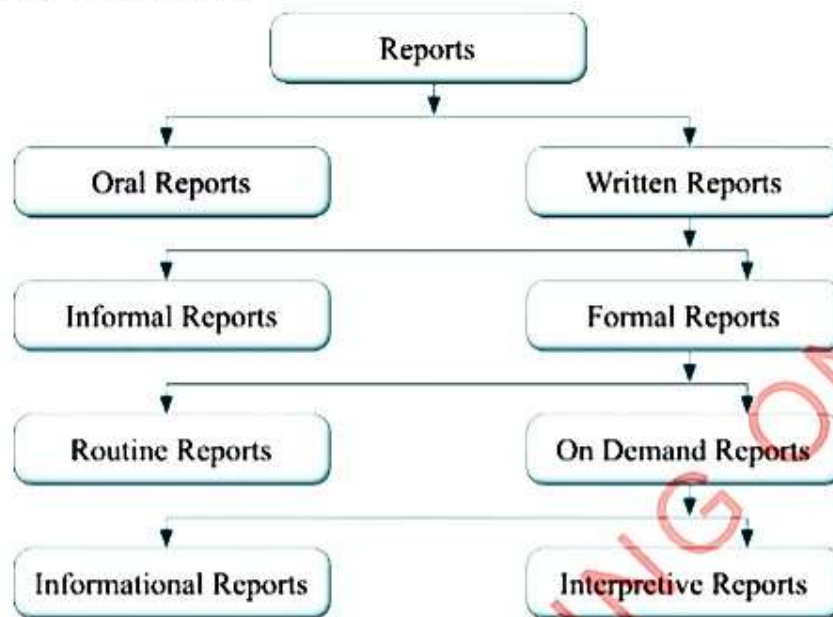


Figure 3.1: Types of reports (Shukla, 2022)

Routine reports

These reports relate to the day-to-day activities of an organisation. Many well-performing organisations rely on these reports in their activities. Examples of routine reports are progress reports, laboratory reports, inventory reports, and annual employee confidential reports. The following paragraphs describe progress reports and laboratory reports.

Progress report

Progress reports are useful for an organisation that has carried out a long-term project, such as the construction of a power plant, an irrigation dam, or a factory. These reports aim to inform management of the progress achieved, enabling informed decisions, for example, on how much additional funding, materials, or workforce are required to complete the task. Government institutions rely heavily on these reports to determine whether progress is being made toward achieving the goal. Progress reports may be periodic or on-demand.

Laboratory reports

Science and engineering involve conducting laboratory experiments to test theories or verify findings. These experiments require the ability to select appropriate equipment, arrange it, observe and record procedures, reactions, and readings, and finally draw valid conclusions. A laboratory report documents all these steps, findings, and conclusions logically. A valid scientific report should present such key components. However, the structure of these reports may vary across organisations.

On-demand reports

As noted earlier, on-demand reports are created only when a specific need or situation arises. Unlike routine reports, which are prepared regularly, on-demand reports are produced in response to a particular problem, request, or decision. Their structure and content vary

according to the purpose, providing targeted information to help organisations address immediate issues. For example, workshop coordinators may request an attendance registration report to obtain a clear picture of participants, enabling them to plan logistical provisions such as meals, transport, accommodation, and recreational services. Another example of an on-demand is when the government establishes a special committee to investigate an issue and determine how similar incidents can be prevented in the future.



Activity 3.1

Visit any office available in your community (for example, a school, church, mosque, or village) and identify at least two types of reports that are not covered in this section (whether a routine or an on-demand report). For each report, find out its type, the writer(s), purpose, its structure, and how it is used in decision-making. Then, write a two-page report presenting your findings. Your report should include the following:

- Title
- An introduction explaining where you went and why
- A description of the reports you discovered
- A comparison between those reports and the types listed in the textbook
- A conclusion describing what you learned about the types of reports
- A statement explaining the type of report you have written.



Exercise 3.1

Having read the text about purposes and types of reports, think about real-life situations, for example, health workers, government officials, school prefects, journalists, or students. Then, complete the following task in your notebook:

- List two or more purposes of report writing that were not mentioned in the text.
- Explain a situation where each purpose might apply.
- Identify who the report would be written for in each case.

Key features of a good report

A good report takes into account several important qualities, including the following:

Quality	Description
Written with a clear purpose	Define the objective of your report before writing. Stay focused on that purpose throughout.
Specific audience	Understand who will read your report before writing. Therefore, analyse your audience before preparing the report. This will help ensure that the content, language, and scope of the report align with the audience's capacity, culture, expectations, and needs.
Objectivity and accuracy	Present factual information and avoid bias, personal opinions and emotions.

Quality	Description
Logical structure	Prepare an outline of your report's structure. Then follow the key sections when writing the report (e.g., introduction, body, conclusion) in a well-organised manner.
Use evidence	It is necessary to give evidence from data or sources to support arguments or to show the authenticity of an academic report. Avoid false information, unconfirmed or unauthorised information. Violation of these requirements has serious consequences, including being discontinued from studies, civil or criminal charges, or missing opportunities related to the required report.
Appropriate language	Use formal language and observe grammatical structures, logic, and punctuation that convey the intended meaning. Edit the language before submitting the report.
Information source	Explain how the information/data was obtained; for example, through observation, interviews, surveys, reading, or questionnaires.
Clarity and conciseness	Do not overload the report with unnecessary information. You can achieve this by using simple, direct language while avoiding repetition, jargon, and ambiguity that may confuse the reader.



Activity 3.2

- Visit a library or online sources to access at least two reports and analyse them by answering the following guiding questions:
 - Which report appears to be objective? Why?
 - What evidence supports the arguments?
 - Are there sources cited? Are they trustworthy?
 - How does the use of references or evidence strengthen the credibility of the report?
- Access one academic report from authentic sources. Read the report carefully and respond to the following questions:
 - What features of formal language can you identify in this report?
 - How does the author use grammar, punctuation, and sentence structure to ensure clarity?
 - What strategies make the argument flow logically from one section to the next?
 - Which techniques from this report could you apply to improve your own academic writing?

Structure of a report

The essential sections of a report are introduction, body, and conclusion, which are similar to those of a classroom or take-home essay. However, the sections of a report and an essay serve different functions. Contrary to classroom essays, the introduction, body, and conclusion of a report slightly differ. Academic reports also include other specific sections: the title page, table of contents, executive summary/abstract, reference list, and appendices. However, some sections may not be included depending on the terms of reference provided. It is important to consult authorities or read guidelines before starting to write a report. If you are asked to include these sections, insert them in the correct place relative to the main sections. The following diagram summarises these key elements:

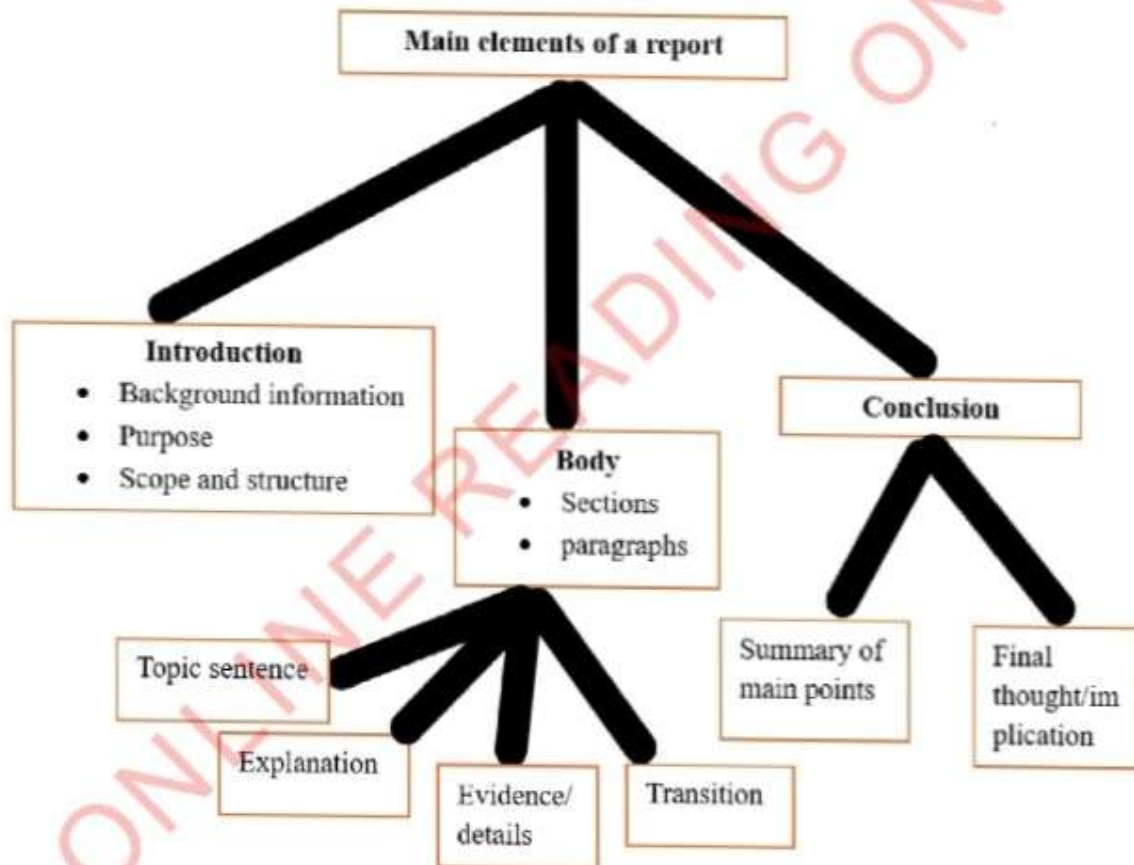


Figure 3.2: Main elements of a report

Each of these main elements of a report is described in the following table:

Section	Description
Introduction	The purpose of the introduction in a report is to inform the reader about the problem's context and reality, which contributed to the need for the report. Here, the reader is made aware of the magnitude and effects of the problem, or the benefits of the problem, if any. The introduction also explains key terms to help the reader understand the report's contents. The introduction also states the report's specific objectives and provides a thesis statement.

Section	Description
Body	The body is the main part of the report, presenting the key arguments or ideas derived from data analysis. These arguments or ideas are organised into paragraphs, with each paragraph containing a single argument or idea, an explanation of the reasoning, supporting data or information, and a concluding statement. The paragraphs are arranged under titled sections corresponding to the report's specific objectives.
Conclusion	The purpose of the conclusion in a report is to summarise the main points presented in the body and provide a final thought or implication based on those points.

The components described in the table above represent the main sections of a report. However, these are just basic sections of a report. Long reports usually include additional sections that support the overall structure and presentation, though they are not part of the core content. Except for the title page, which can be prepared first, most of these sections are written after completing the main report since their content depends on the information in the body. The following outlines additional sections of a report.

- (a) The title page – This contains the title of the report, the author(s) and the intended recipient or reader of the report.
- (b) Executive summary/abstract – A summary that provides a gist of the report. It includes the report's objectives, the methods used to gather the information, the main findings or arguments, and the conclusion and or recommendations.
- (c) Table of contents – It is a list of the information that is contained in a report and the pages on which it is found.
- (d) List of abbreviations – They are short forms of long words or phrases used in the main document.
- (e) Reference list – This is a list of references that are cited in the relevant report. Citations can be sourced from books, journal articles, newspapers, personal conversations with stakeholders, or media reports. Make sure that each quotation is referenced and inserted into the list of references.
- (f) Appendices – Additional details referenced in the report. They are included as appendices because they may take up a lot of space or disrupt the flow of the report's arguments. They can include pictures, maps, newspaper clippings, or notices.



Exercise 3.2

1. Explain why reports are important in academic and community life.
2. Name types of reports used in schools, workplaces, or communities.
3. Explain why objectivity and accuracy are important in report writing.
4. What are the essential sections of a report? How do they differ from the sections of an essay?
5. Describe three supplementary sections that may appear in a report. When are these usually prepared?
6. Why is it important to use headings and subheadings in your report?
7. Describe different ways of collecting information during the pre-writing stage.

Steps in writing a report

The report writing process, like any form of writing, involves following a systematic writing process. It consists of three main stages: pre-writing, writing, and post-writing. Each stage includes specific steps that ensure clarity and a good organisation of the report.

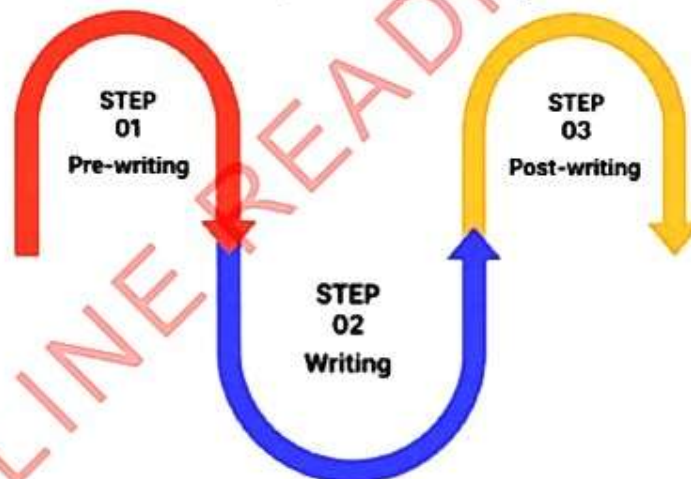


Figure 3.3: Steps in writing a report



Exercise 3.3

Read the text on the steps in writing a report and answer the questions that follow.

Pre-writing step

This is a stage where you either generate an idea or are assigned a topic for the report. Clearly identify the target recipient or readers and the purpose of the report. Then, determine the components or terms of reference that outline what should be included in the report. Next, gather resources and information to support the report. The pre-writing step involves reading and consulting knowledgeable individuals. It may also include conducting surveys or making observations. Finally, prepare an outline that shows the report's structure. Preparing an outline helps you organise your ideas clearly and logically and prevents you from missing important parts of the report.

The writing step

Organise the report in a clear, systematic structure, following the sections explained earlier. Ensure each section flows logically and cohesively, using headings and sub-headings to make your report easy to follow. Support the information presented using authentic evidence/data. Acknowledge the source of every information you use from other works using the appropriate referencing style (e.g., APA, MLA, Harvard).

Post-writing step

This step involves editing and proofreading the report. It is sometimes referred to as the second eye and pencil. After finalising your draft report, revise and edit it for clarity, accuracy, and coherence. Consider peer or supervisor feedback to improve the quality of the content. Lastly, ensure that the report meets any specific formatting or submission requirements provided by your institution or organisation.

Language and style in reports

The language for report writing is formal, brief, and objective, with consideration of the audience and purpose. Writers use impartial language or the passive voice. Therefore, abstain from using personal pronouns in academic reports. This ensures that the content focuses more on arguments than on your opinions. Punctuation, grammar, and writing must be correct to convey accurate meaning. Reflective information or that which contains statistics is often presented in charts, graphs, or tables and referenced to the main text to enhance the readers' understanding.

Questions

1. What is the purpose of the pre-writing stage in the report writing process?
2. Describe two ways you can collect information for your report during the pre-writing stage.
3. What is meant by the phrase "second eye and pencil" in the post-writing stage?



Activity 3.3

1. Prepare a clear outline that you will apply when producing a well-structured academic report that includes all essential sections.
2. Use one of your previously written essays and highlight the following elements:
 - (a) Objectives of the report
 - (b) Methods used to gather information
 - (c) Key findings or arguments
 - (d) Conclusion and/or recommendations
 - (e) Write an executive summary of the report in no more than one page.

Referencing and citations

Referencing is an important section in any formal report, as it ensures the information presented is authentic, ethically sourced, and traceable. While Chapter Seven of this textbook is dedicated to referencing and citation styles, it is important to explain here how referencing is specifically essential in the context of report writing. It gives evidence of the materials used, helps you to avoid plagiarism, and supports your findings. Referencing in a report is done through in-text citations; that is, throughout the report when information is taken from another source. Then, a reference list is prepared and put at the end of the report. It includes all sources cited in the main report.



Revision questions

1. Why are reports important in academic, professional, and community settings, and how do their purposes differ across these contexts?
2. What is the difference between formal and informal reports, and why are informal reports considered rare?
3. In what ways do progress reports assist organisations that manage long-term projects?
4. Explain why objectivity is essential in report writing, and describe practical strategies writers can use to maintain it.
5. What key features make a report effective, and which of these features do you think writers struggle with most? Why?
6. Why is it essential to identify a report's audience before writing it, and how can the audience influence language and structure?
7. What role does evidence play in report writing, and what might happen if a report lacks credible evidence?

Speaking with confidence and clarity

Introduction

Speaking confidently and clearly is an important skill that should be taken seriously, as it helps one deliver the intended message effectively. In this chapter, you will learn techniques for speaking confidently and effectively on a range of topics in different settings. You will specifically learn and practise speaking formally and logically in various familiar settings, such as funerals, parties, and at home. The competencies gained will help you speak confidently and meaningfully, while also employing both the emotional and practical aspects to deliver memorable presentations in different contexts.

Think

What makes one become a good speaker in academic settings

Speaking in academic settings

Speaking in academic settings aims to benefit your audience by providing information, issuing a warning or encouraging a behaviour change. You should understand that when you are chosen to speak or present something, you are trusted as someone knowledgeable on the topic or as the discussion leader - you are expected to know the topic well, whether it is health, a bereavement, a celebration, or an informational presentation. Use a stronger and more encouraging voice than in regular conversation. You need to prepare and rehearse for public speaking as soon as you realise that you have to give a speech.



Exercise 4.1

Think of an occasion where you spoke in public—at school, church, a mosque or a birthday party. Write a brief self-assessment using the following guide:

- What you did well
- What you did not do well
- What made you feel confident
- What made you feel nervous
- Specific steps you will take to improve your next presentation

Things to consider when speaking in academic settings

Speaking in academic settings requires a balance of content preparation, audience engagement, and professional discipline. An effective academic presentation observes the principles of presentation. However, those principles may be adapted to the presentation's context. Some of the general principles for academic speaking include the following:

Capturing attention

Skilled speakers begin their talks by piquing the audience's interest in what they are presenting. The speaker can create this interest by starting with an attention-grabber (hook), such as a story, an attention-grabbing question, or a quote from a famous person, and linking it to the topic. The use of attention-grabbers at the start of a presentation is not optional; it is a deliberate technique to connect with the audience and lead them into the presentation.

Use notes and practice

Well-prepared notes will guide delivery without encouraging verbatim reading. Prepare notes in an outline form that will allow you to refer to key ideas. It is advised that you use a large font size between 13 and 14, and leave space between main points. This will allow you to maintain eye contact and interaction with the audience as you present.

Rehearse before speaking

Rehearse your presentation by practising in an isolated place as if it were the actual presentation. Practising aloud serves a dual purpose: identifying points that flow easily versus those that are challenging. Rehearsal is not only about memory but also about refining performance and ensuring fluency within time limits. Being cautious not to exceed the planned duration underscores the social etiquette of academic speaking: respect for organisers and the audience's schedule. Time management emerges as both a technical and ethical responsibility.

Arrive on time

Arriving early to check the stage, layout, and sound equipment reflects professional responsibility and good time management. It helps ensure a smooth delivery and avoids wasting the audience's time with technical adjustments during the presentation.



Activity 4.1

1. Create an attention-grabber for an introduction (a question, short story, or quotation) and practise presenting it individually in a quiet space.
2. Prepare an introduction for a presentation on any topic. Rehearse presenting it and then assess yourself using the following guiding questions:
 - (a) Will it capture attention effectively?
 - (b) Could you use notes appropriately without reading word-for-word?
 - (c) Did the presentation flow logically within the time limit?
 - (d) Write a short reflection: "What I did well in my presentation and what I will improve next time."



Exercise 4.2

Listen to a short recorded academic presentation/speech and respond to the following questions:

- Identify the techniques the speaker employed to capture attention.
- Identify what made the presentation effective.
- What would you add to further improve the presentation?

Speaking on various issues

Speaking on health issues

People often speak about health issues in public settings for several important reasons. Individuals sometimes encounter situations in which they must discuss health issues, perhaps to influence funding, community support, or policies. At times, prevailing circumstances, such as outbreaks and emergencies, may require someone to address public health concerns. In such a situation, several considerations are needed to ensure that the message is effective, accurate and appropriate.

Know your audience

One of the first considerations when discussing health is analysing your audience. You need to understand their characteristics, i.e., their education level, age, sex, and expectations. It is also important to understand what they already know about the topic, what they need from you, and which issues matter most to them. This information will help you choose a relevant topic and prepare accurate, up-to-date content. Speak by relevant data or citing health information from authorities like health specialists, government health institutions, or organisations like the WHO. Generally, effective audience analysis helps ensure that health communication is relevant, credible and impactful.

Language

Use straightforward language that your audience can understand. Avoid using jargon but use layman's language. For example, the Kiswahili term for placenta, '*kondo la nyuma*', may not be sufficient for local communities. Such terms often need further elaboration with examples drawn from the community. Your choice of words and posture should demonstrate confidence. Speaking about public health seeks to change people's behaviour and practices, thus speaking with confidence while paying attention to your body language will engage the audience and influence them to change or accept information.

Ethics

Human health issues are inherently sensitive and personal. Therefore, discussions about them must respect confidentiality. Avoid sharing unconfirmed information or hearsay. Health information should come from authorised persons, such as medical officers, a

government official, or health professionals. Sources of health information should be reliable. For example, you may draw references from credible institutions such as the WHO, official statistical reports, and other recognised health authorities. In general, ethical health communication requires respecting privacy, verifying information, and relying on credible sources before sharing any message.



Activity 4.2

Imagine you are a health worker at the ward hospital. You have been invited to deliver a speech on the cholera epidemic at a village or street meeting. Then, do the following:

1. Research on the topic using your school library or any other sources of information.
2. Document the information and prepare for the speech delivery.
3. Act out delivering the speech.

Speaking at solemn or commemorative events

Speaking at funerals, memorial services, or farewell ceremonies requires sensitivity, personalisation, and cultural awareness. In such moments, the speaker's role is not only to honour the deceased, the person being remembered or celebrated, but also to offer comfort, encouragement, and a sense of togetherness to the audience by using appropriate language and tone. People are usually invited to speak because of their relationship with the family or the deceased. This implies that they are expected to bring authentic, personal insights about the deceased or a person being honoured—whether as a friend, relative, colleague, supervisor, mentee or respected community member. This means that the speaker is expected to bring authentic insights drawn from real experiences.

Therefore, when speaking at any solemn or commemorative event, begin by introducing yourself and stating your relationship with the person you are honouring. For funeral and memorial services, share meaningful memories, lessons learned and values you observed in the deceased. For farewell events, highlight the person's contributions, strengths, and joyful moments that reflect their journey and impact.

Your tone and choice of words should reflect the nature of the occasion. In mourning contexts, language should be gentle, consoling, and respectful of family and friends' emotions. Some communities have particular expressions used during funerals and memorials, and religious quotations - from sources such as the Holy Bible and the Qur'an are also common among Christian and Muslim communities, respectively. These may be used to console, greet mourners, or offer a farewell to the deceased. At farewell ceremonies, by contrast, the tone may remain respectful but more hopeful and appreciative, focusing on gratitude and best wishes.

If you are asked to deliver a eulogy, ensure that it is well-structured and begin practising it at least a day before the funeral or memorial service. At the end of the speech, it is appropriate to console the family of the deceased and, if applicable, offer a short prayer. In farewell speeches, conclude by expressing gratitude, offering best wishes, and acknowledging the person's contributions. Regardless of the type of event, your words should show empathy, respect, and cultural understanding.



Activity 4.3

Choose one of the following scenarios and prepare a 2–3-minute speech for the selected event.

Scenarios

1. A memorial service: You have been invited to speak at a community memorial in honour of a respected neighbour who contributed to youth development.
2. A funeral: A close family friend (imaginary) has passed away, and the family has asked you to share a short reflection (eulogy) during the funeral service.
3. A farewell ceremony: Your school is bidding farewell to a long-serving teacher who is retiring, and you have been chosen to give a tribute.

Your speech should:

4. Introduce yourself and your relationship to the person being honoured.
5. Sharing one or two meaningful memories, lessons, or contributions related to the person.
6. Use culturally or religiously appropriate and familiar phrases from Tanzanian contexts where suitable.
7. Use tone and language appropriate for the occasion (mourning, remembrance, or respectful farewell).

Speaking at a celebration

Successful speaking at a celebration depends not only on the content of your topics but also on how you deliver them entertainingly, taking into account the type of celebration, cultural considerations, the speaker's ability to adapt to the circumstances, and ways to make participants enjoy the event. This section discusses the key factors to consider when called to speak at a celebration.

Pre-event presence and interaction

Pre-event presence and interaction are critical factors in shaping the speaker's comfort, credibility, and connection with both organisers and audience. Arrive early and check the sound system. Also, meet the event organisers, the floor manager, and other important people to discuss what the event will be like. Mingle with the audience and have fun with them. You also need to continue interactions with the audience when you are not on the stage. This fosters rapport and cooperation, enabling the event to run more smoothly and

ensuring the speaker is aligned with the team. Having fun with the audience establishes a light, positive atmosphere, especially useful for celebratory or community-based events.

Remember to read and rehearse your script in advance. Preparation through script reading helps internalise the flow of the event and improves the speaker's delivery and stage presence. The more familiar you are with the material, the less you rely on it physically, freeing you to focus on connection rather than content. Reducing reliance on paper helps maintain eye contact, read the room, and build a stronger presence.

Deliver an opening remark at ceremonies

Give a strategic and emotional entry point into a formal or celebratory event. You can do this through gratitude, tone-setting, and personal introduction. This will enhance audience engagement and set the stage for a memorable experience. See the following example:

Ladies and gentlemen, it is a pleasure to have you all here today - a warm welcome to all. We look forward to an engaging and meaningful event. Thank you for being here.

Then, introduce yourself and create a memorable experience for the people. Make them remember you by introducing yourself.

Allow me to introduce myself, I am Faraja Upendo from..... It is my honour to guide you through this celebration. Let us make this moment count together.

Know your audience before you speak.

There are two pillars of effective event speaking: In-depth audience analysis and professional speaker preparation and coordination. Knowing your audience is essential, not optional. You can do this through cultural awareness, listening to past experiences, and seeking local insight. Research the people or the community in the event – their stories and culture. Also, research their previous celebration events to help you understand how to become a good fit for them.

If you are an MC, speak with the main speakers before you call them to the stage. Let them know that you will introduce them and check whether you pronounce their names correctly. This will help you build trust with the speaker and avoid embarrassment. Identify what they will discuss or present, and verify that it aligns with the provided schedule. Know their bios so that you can introduce them well and make the audience eager to listen to the speaker.

Dress for the event

Begin preparing your outfit as soon as you are confirmed as a speaker. Start preparing what to wear for the celebration. Appearance is part of your preparation, as are content and rehearsal. It communicates that what you wear matters, not as pride, but as part of your professional and social presence at the event. You have to dress well and be one of the well-dressed people at the party.

Handle unexpected gaps during live events

It is important to know how to handle unexpected delays or gaps during an event, especially from the perspective of a host or an MC. It is important to prepare to adapt and engage the audience to ensure smooth management of live events. When things do not go exactly as scheduled, such as when a speaker is not ready, the host should be prepared to “kill time” effectively and maintain the event’s energy and flow. It could be music or interesting stories.

Offer a closing wish for the event

Decide on a solid and purposeful closing strategy for a ceremonial speech. A good closing of a celebration creates a lasting emotional impression and helps tie everything together with a sense of hope, purpose, or unity. You can conclude a ceremony by offering a closing wish for the event, summarising key messages, thanking the audience, and inviting reflection. This is important to help the audience mentally and emotionally conclude the experience. Appreciating the audience makes you, the speaker, appear gracious and reinforces the collective nature of ceremonies.

**Activity 4.4**

You have been invited to speak at a celebration (e.g., a school award ceremony, a cultural event, or a community festivity).

1. Review key factors to consider when allowed to speak at a celebration.
2. Prepare a 5-minute celebratory speech that includes:
 - (a) A warm opening remark to capture attention and set a positive tone.
 - (b) Self-introduction and connection to the audience or event.
 - (c) An anecdote, observation, or relevant stories that make the speech entertaining and meaningful.
 - (d) A closing wish or summary that leaves a positive impression.
3. Act out delivering your speech.

Speaking in school settings

Speaking at school is crucial not only for academic success but also for future career development. It will help you develop confidence in communication and leadership. A common barrier in public speaking is the fear of speaking in front of others. This fear can be overcome through sufficient practice and preparation, which helps you build confidence and organise your thoughts and ideas clearly. Remember that public speaking is a skill that can be developed, rather than an innate ability. Please take advantage of the opportunities available at school, as it is a safer environment for you to practice. These platforms include debates, presentations, clubs, and various school events and forums.

Observe the basic elements of public speaking structure: introduction, body, and conclusion. Importantly, speakers should not explicitly announce these sections during their presentation;

instead, they should allow the speech to flow naturally within this framework. This will help you maintain professionalism and engagement.

Use clear, simple language to ensure the message is accessible to the audience. Non-verbal communication, voice modulation, eye contact, and body language are vital components that enhance the speaker's connection with the audience and the effectiveness of delivery.



Activity 4.5

Imagine you have been asked to deliver a 5-minute speech on healthy eating among youths during the School Baraza. Then, do the following:

1. Research on the topic using your school library and any other sources of information.
2. Document the information and prepare for speech delivery.
3. Act out delivering the speech.

Speaking in a home environment

Effective public speaking is not developed solely in formal settings such as schools. Frequent speaking practice at home provides a foundational context for developing practical public speaking skills. Therefore, the home environment is an informal training ground for nurturing communication skills. The home provides a safe and comfortable space, reducing anxiety and encouraging free expression. Regular interactions at home help individuals practice verbal expression, thought organisation, and coherent communication. Family members can provide feedback, which accelerates learning and improvement. Always speak courteously and use appropriate language at home, regardless of the age or status of the family member you are addressing.

Speaking at home will help to develop and shape linguistic skills informally, such as structuring sentences and articulating ideas clearly. Therefore, it is important to engage in conversations and expression at home regularly to build confidence and communication skills.



Activity 4.6

1. Imagine you have been asked, as a family member, to deliver a vote of thanks to those who participated in the wedding ceremony. Then do the following:
 - (a) Make quick preparation for a short speech.
 - (b) Act out delivering the speech.
2. Imagine you have just been elected a clan leader. Then do the following:
 - (a) Prepare a short speech to thank the audience and explain what you expect and what they should expect from your leadership.
 - (b) Act out delivering the speech.

3. One of your parents asks you to study a course at a higher learning institution that you are not interested in. Organise a short talk to present at a family meeting to convince your parent to allow you to study the course of your preference, explaining why you chose it.
4. Your family is planning a traditional ceremony where some outdated traditional practices will take place, and you have just remembered that you learned at school that such practices are unacceptable and unlawful. Prepare a short talk to present to the family explaining why they should not practise them.

Speaking at the workplace

Communication at work is centred on pride in excellent performance, participation, engagement, and accountability. Its emphasis is on moving people from just obeying rules to taking ownership. Most frequently, when you get the opportunity to talk at the workplace, talk about teamwork. Discussing caring for the people you work with and respecting your teammates is important, as it reflects respect for yourself. Also, discuss courtesy, which is a major contributor to performance at work: Say hello to people. This makes you approachable – smile at people. You may say something funny, make yourself genuine and natural. You need to demonstrate respect for the people you work with. Often, observe the following issues when speaking:

- i) Speak with clarity, enthusiasm, and confidence to draw people into what you are saying. Do these while connecting with your audience.
- ii) Keep your communication simple. The primary goal of your communication is to make sure that everyone understands what you are saying.
- iii) Be open-minded: Listen to other people's views. You can tell them that this is my view – can I hear your point of view – what is your point of view, so that we may conclude.
- iv) Comment politely, using expressions like “I agree with your argument. Once we strengthen discipline, everything else will fall into place, as discipline is the foundation for all of this.” Or “I see your point; however, without a clear vision, progress will be limited, since vision guides all other efforts.”
- v) Nonverbal communication: This accounts for 70-90% of communication. When we are silent, people receive approximately 90% of the message, even if we think we are sending something different. Learn how to leverage nonverbal communication to ensure you are sending the right message.
- vi) Maintain eye contact: Be clear with your message. It is not another person's job to infer what you mean. State your message clearly. Try to put your message in a context that another person can understand.
- vii) Control your emotions: If someone says something that offends you, demonstrate your professionalism and maintain your cool. You may need to correct misinformation, but do so in a cool, calm manner. If you do not control your emotions, you may ruin the presentation. Even when you are excited, do not exhibit signs of overexcitability.

**Activity 4.7**

Imagine you are a health worker at a hospital ward, and you have been asked to deliver a speech on Malaria at a village or street meeting. Then, do the following:

1. Research on the topic using your school library and any other sources of information.
2. Document the information and prepare for the speech delivery.
3. Act out delivering the speech to your fellow students in class.

**Revision questions**

1. Discuss the essential elements that contribute to confident and clear speaking in academic settings.
2. Compare and contrast academic, commemorative, and celebrative speeches, highlighting how context shapes language choice, organisation, and delivery.
3. Imagine you have been appointed to address a school gathering on reproductive health. Please describe how you would organise your speech, adapt it to your audience, and ensure that your communication is both impactful and culturally appropriate.
4. Discuss how one's mindset, readiness to practise, and openness to feedback can influence their growth as a speaker.
5. Discuss how practising public speaking can transform students' confidence, persuasion, and social engagement both at school and in the community.

Crafting clear and professional messages

Introduction

Workers in organisations need to know how to communicate professionally across multiple platforms while also managing responses and interactions in ways that preserve relationships and organisational credibility. In this chapter, you will learn about etiquette and professionalism in communication. Specifically, you will learn to use various professional communication platforms and strategies to manage interactions, particularly when providing online feedback. The competencies developed will help you communicate effectively while maintaining proper manners, tone, clarity, and structure.



Think

What is involved in writing professional messages

Writing emails

Emails are among the fastest and most common means of communication in the workplace. A good email is clear, polite, and concise. It shows professionalism and helps the recipient understand exactly what they need to do. A professional email has the following parts:

1. Subject line
2. Recipient(s)
3. Salutation
4. Purpose / Main message
5. Closing remark
6. Signature

1. Subject line (What is the email about?)

Keep it short and action-focused, for example, "Request to Use the Photocopier." The most common mistake is using informal or vague subject lines that do not state the primary purpose, such as "Hello" or "Urgent!!!".

2. Recipient(s) (Who should receive the email?)

Add the correct email addresses and double-check before sending. A good example is

To: head@school.ac.tz

Cc: secretary@school.ac.tz

Ensure that unintended recipients are omitted. The most common mistake many people make is copying people who are not involved.

3. Salutation (How do you greet the recipient?)

Be polite and direct. Avoid using overly informal and lengthy greetings. Examples:

- (a) Dear Ms Amina Hussein,
- (b) Hello Sir/Madam,

Use short, warm wishes

- (a) I hope you are well.
- (b) I hope your week is going smoothly.
- (c) I hope this email finds you well.

4. Purpose/main message (Why are you writing?)

State the primary purpose in *the first sentence*. Add the necessary details after the purpose. Avoid writing long stories before stating the purpose. A good example is as follows:

I am writing to request permission to use the school photocopier to photocopy copies of the Form Six chapter for revision. We need 40 copies of Chapter 4 for the entire class; the file is attached.

Could you please confirm whether we may use the photocopier on Friday afternoon and whether there is any charge?

5. Closing remark (How do you end the message?)

End politely with a call to action. You should not end an email abruptly. The following are examples of ways to end an email.

- (a) Thank you for your time.
- (b) I look forward to your feedback.
- (c) Please let me know if you need more information.

6. Signature

Include the following information for your signature:

- (a) Your full name (e.g., Mary Joseph)
- (b) Your position /class (e.g., Head Prefect, Form Six)
- (c) Institution (e.g., Mkwajuni Secondary School)
- (d) Your phone number (if required)

You must review your email for clarity and accuracy. You could do this by reading your email aloud, paying attention to each word. The following quick checklist is also useful before sending your email:

1. Are names, dates, and details accurate?
2. Is the purpose clear in the first line?
3. Is the tone polite?
4. Is the email short?
5. Did you review spelling and punctuation?
6. Have you checked your contact information and signature?
7. Have you verified the attachment?



Activity 5.1

Follow the steps below to draft a professional email, review it with the quick checklist, and practise sending it.

Step 1 — Use the template (fill in the blanks)

Copy this template into a computer or write it down:

Subject: _____

To: _____ **Cc:** _____

Dear _____,

I hope you are well.

I am writing to _____. (State purpose in one sentence.)

(Short context / 2–3 facts — only what is necessary)

Please could you _____? (State the action you want.)

Thank you for your time.

Kind regards,

Your full name

Form / Position, School

Step 2 - Draft (Do it now)

Write an email using the template for only one of the following prompts:

- (a) Request to use the school photocopier for chapter printing.
- (b) Ask the librarian to reserve the computer lab for revision.
- (c) Request permission to buy materials for a class project.

Make sure your first sentence states the purpose.

Step 3 - Check and grade

Use the Quick Checklist to ensure that it is professional:

Quick Checklist (tick ✓ or X)

- ☐ The purpose is clear in the first line
- ☐ The subject line is short and action-focused
- ☐ Right recipients / Cc used correctly
- ☐ Polite salutation and closing
- ☐ The email is short — only the necessary details are included.
- ☐ Spelling, grammar, punctuation OK
- ☐ The signature section contains the name, class/position, and school

Write one short suggestion for improvement (maximum 12 words).

Step 4 - Edit and finalise

Read your final version aloud once to check clarity.

Step 5 - Send

Now that your email sounds professional, you can click the 'Send' button.

**Exercise 5.2**

Why is it important for young Tanzanians to learn how to communicate professionally through online platforms?

Writing on online professional platforms and portals

In addition to using social media for public interaction and customer engagement, professionals today also use online platforms for more formal, career-oriented communication. Social media builds community awareness and brand identity. Hence, they require respectful, timely, and purposeful communication, whether you are replying to a client's message or sharing an update with your network. Understanding how to use each platform effectively strengthens your professional image and improves how you share information in the digital world.

Ways to communicate on professional platforms

- (a) **Post content:** Share updates, short articles, or achievements such as completing a project, attending a seminar, or volunteering. This helps your network know what you are learning and accomplishing.
- (b) **Use direct messaging:** Send polite, personalised messages to teachers, professionals, or classmates to request advice, mentorship, or collaboration.

- (c) **Comment on posts:** Contribute meaningfully to discussions by commenting thoughtfully on other people's posts. In addition to general replies like "Nice post", include ideas or questions that keep the conversation going.
- (d) **Participate in groups:** Join groups related to your interests or career goals, such as Education in Tanzania or Young African Entrepreneurs, to learn, share experiences, and connect with like-minded people.
- (e) **Share recommendations and endorsements:** When you recommend or endorse someone's skills, it helps both of you build credibility and strengthen your professional reputation.
- (f) **Engage with your network:** Reply to comments and messages promptly and politely. This shows professionalism and helps you maintain strong connections.

Strategies for effective online communication

- (a) **Be authentic:** Communicate naturally and honestly while maintaining a respectful professional tone—just as you would in a face-to-face conversation with a teacher or employer.
- (b) **Personalise your messages:** Avoid copying the same message for everyone. When connecting with someone, mention how you know them or why you want to connect.
- (c) **Do your research:** Before sending a message or comment, read the person's profile or post carefully. This helps you communicate meaningfully and respectfully.
- (d) **Be responsive:** Try to reply to messages and comments within a few days to keep your communication active and reliable.
- (e) **Be professional:** Always use correct grammar, polite language, and a positive tone. Avoid slang, gossip, or negative remarks that could harm your reputation.

Example

If you are a Form Five or Six student interested in education, you might post something like:

I recently participated in a community tutoring project at our school to help younger pupils improve their reading skills. It was a great learning experience, and I hope to continue developing my skills in teaching and leadership.

Such a post not only informs others of your achievements but also shows your initiative and community spirit, qualities valued in both local and international professional settings.



Activity 5.2

Volunteer at an event and then write a short post of three to five lines. Your post must be polite and factual, mention what you learned, avoid slang or informal emojis, and include a call to action.

Another aim of online communication is to respond to messages from others, whether known or unknown. Maintaining a professional, authentic, and respectful communication style is necessary for both ends. Some people may not respond directly to messages but may engage with participants through likes or comments. Others may appreciate a gentle follow-up on your products or services, as illustrated below.

Hello Faraja!

Thank you for visiting our page. We love you, our follower and client! I saw you liked our recent post about the new product in our organisation. We would welcome hearing from you. Please let us know how we can assist you. If you have questions, our staff has been serving our customers for years. You can find me in office No. 104B if you need anything.

I am looking forward to hearing from you.

Kind regards,

(Name)

(Signature)



Exercise 5.2

Write a short post introducing yourself and sharing one academic or community achievement. Include a short greeting or statement of purpose, the activity or achievement, and a reflection or lesson learned.

(a) Dealing with hateful comments online

As long as you post content on social media to increase followers and customers and meet customer satisfaction, you will find some people who disagree with you. You are likely to encounter hateful comments online. You need to prevent negative comments from affecting your real life and learn to distinguish between hateful remarks and constructive feedback. Therefore, do not respond in an emotional or hateful way. Use constructive feedback to improve yourself, your work, and your organisation. Recognise your own value and remember that your audience consists of strangers, not friends or relatives who would not leave such comments.

If you receive negative comments, know that you are growing and interacting with strangers. Negative comments indicate the influence of your work. Thus, be proud of your work. In most cases, individuals who post hateful comments are anonymous. You do not know them, and you cannot see them because they make themselves invisible. They would not say it in person because they know it is wrong, which is why they conceal their identity. Review the thread and take any helpful feedback for future use. Filter the hateful and emotional language from the feedback that you can use and let the hateful comments go.

Some people make hateful comments because they do not understand social norms, so when you see such comments, remember the problem lies with them, not with you. They are projecting their own flaws onto you. You may review a person's profile containing hateful comments and determine whether you can engage with them. If you engage with them, do so carefully and respectfully, for the person understands their pitfall. Model the tone, thank them for their feedback, and point out the language that has offended you, explaining why, to give them the benefit of the doubt.

It is important to recognise that engaging with someone who does not reason may provoke further hateful comments. If a comment contradicts your organisation's practices, clarify your policies and avoid further engagement. This approach can increase the visibility of your content. Also, you may block users whose comments you no longer wish to see.



Revision questions

1. Discuss why professionalism is important in workplace communication, and how it affects organisational relationships.
2. What are the six essential parts of a professional email, and why is each one important?
3. What common mistakes do people make when writing subject lines, and how can these be corrected?
4. Why is it important to review an email before sending it, and which checklist items are most critical?
5. If you want to write an email requesting to use the school hall for a debate, what should your first sentence be?
6. Give an example of a polite closing remark for a professional email. Why is politeness important?
7. Compare emails with online professional posts. In what ways are they similar and different in tone, purpose, and audience?
8. Explain why hateful comments appear online, and how a young professional should distinguish between constructive feedback and harmful remarks.

Writing project proposals and reports

Introduction

A project proposal communicates a project's vision, benefits, and strategic alignment to decision-makers, primarily to secure funding and support. It is important to master project proposal writing skills to maintain effective communication with stakeholders throughout the process. In this chapter, you will learn the significance of writing project proposals, the basic structure, the language and tone, and the proposal writing process. The competencies developed in this chapter will enable you to develop a successful proposal that clearly defines the problem using specific examples and outlines measurable benefits and deliverables.



Think

Certain ideas gain support while others are rejected, and how persuasive writing shapes these outcomes

What is a project proposal?

A project proposal is a document that communicates a project's vision. It also communicates the project's benefits to a target community or organisation. In addition, project proposals lay out key concepts and ideas submitted to convince decision-makers that they can be implemented.

Imagine this scenario: Your fellow students must walk a long distance to purchase school items such as pencils, pens, rulers, mathematical sets, counter books, and plain paper. Consequently, they miss some lessons. You believe this challenge can be addressed by setting up a small stall and selling those items at school. Given this situation, you decide to write a proposal that describes the problem and proposes a solution grounded in the real situation.

Why do people write project proposals?

Generally, people write project proposals for the following reasons:

- i) To communicate to decision-making bodies a vision of the project and its benefits to the target community
- ii) To secure funding and support for implementation
- iii) To undertake a feasibility study, to see if the vision is implementable

A well-prepared project proposal increases the likelihood of receiving funding or support from decision-makers. Funders often review proposals and decide whether the project is worth funding. Therefore, your idea must be presented clearly, logically, and convincingly through the essential elements of a proposal.



Activity 6.1

Study the following scenario and do the tasks that follow:

In Nronga Village, children spend long hours fetching unsafe water from a distant river. This causes absenteeism and poor academic performance, as many children choose to help their parents fetch water rather than attend school. The situation also contributes to frequent cases of stomach illness caused by contaminated water. The community lacks a water tank, and residents struggle to maintain regular hygiene standards.

- State the main problem the project will address, and write the objective of your project.
- Specify one clear and observable deliverable for the project.
- State one measurable indicator to show the project's progress.
- Identify a direct or indirect benefit that would result from the project.
- Suggest one realistic strategy that would help the project continue operating after donors' support ends.

The basic structure of project proposals

Example of a project proposal

Applicant

Name of the organisation: **Tanzanian Form Six Graduates' Group**

Type of organisation: **Civil Society Organisation**

Title: **A community engagement approach for sustainable, environmentally safe, and clean charcoal energy use in Sungu Village**

Project contact name: **Changamka Mapambano**

Email: **tfomsixg@gmail.com**

Phone: **+255 11 100 0200**

Duration: **24 Months**

Target group: **All villagers**

Country: **Tanzania**

Background to the problem

Access to safe and reliable cooking energy is a significant challenge for many rural Tanzanians (**put citations**). This challenge is more pronounced in Sungu Village in Moshi Rural District, Kilimanjaro Region. The shortage of cooking energy is blamed on rapid population growth, urbanisation, indiscriminate tree cutting, and climate change. All these

factors have put great pressure on forests (trees) - the primary source of cooking energy in the village.

Sungu villagers, like many other rural communities, heavily depend on firewood for cooking. The fuel is also used to produce the local brew, *Mbege*. However, overdependence on fuelwood poses a threat to both forests and the climate. As more trees are felled, many Sungu villagers, especially women and children, are forced to walk long distances to collect firewood. Further, the pressure on forest resources is heightened by unregulated logging in protected areas.

This over-dependence on firewood not only contributes to deforestation and climate change but also poses a threat to women and children, who are most affected. Overdependence also triggers frequent conflicts over scarce forest resources between villagers and government authorities.

Despite the government's efforts to support ecological projects at the village level (insert citations), no project has been implemented in Sungu Village. In view of this challenge, this proposal is submitted to examine pertinent issues related to access to clean energy sources in Sungu Village. It is believed that implementing this project will mitigate current challenges, implement mechanisms to curb excessive fuelwood use, and introduce alternative energy sources.

Project objectives

(a) Main objective

To improve access to safe, clean, and reliable energy-saving sources for domestic and community use at Sungu Village.

(b) Specific objectives

- (i) To assess the current state of environmental destruction and demand for cooking energy
- (ii) To create and strengthen community-based groups for intervention measures
- (iii) To mobilise awareness programmes and undertake environmental campaigns across the village
- (iv) To design and develop environmentally friendly activities to revamp environmental destruction at Sungu Village

Success criteria

The benchmarks of success for this project will be as follows:

- (i) Increased use of clean, safe, and environmentally friendly charcoal in Sungu Village
- (ii) Decreased number of trees cut per annum
- (iii) Increased community engagement in environmental protection and conservation measures

Approach and methods

This project will conduct needs assessment, engage the community, and implement capacity building, participatory planning, and monitoring and evaluation.

Needs assessment

The needs assessment will seek to achieve the following:

- (i) Assess the current energy needs at Sungu Village*
- (ii) Conduct meetings with the community and consult important stakeholders*

Infrastructure development

- (i) To build a charcoal production centre and a storage house*
- (ii) To manufacture safe charcoal packaging facilities*
- (iii) To establish a seedbed facility for growing young trees*
- (iv) To introduce demonstration plots for environmentally friendly activities*

Capacity building

- (i) The community will be educated on clean, safe and environmentally friendly charcoal and the impact of environmental degradation*
- (ii) Village members will be trained in charcoal production, governance and management*
- (iii) Village members will be educated on gender equity and equality to ensure women and youth participation in charcoal production and management.*

Monitoring and Evaluation

- (i) To establish a monitoring and evaluation (M&E) team and mechanisms to ensure functionality and sustainability*
- (ii) To ensure regular field follow-ups for support and to check project progress*
- (iii) Prepare quarterly reports*

Budget

The budget needs to be well-detailed, with each project item clearly described and its estimated cost provided. It is also important to include contingency costs, typically 5% of the overall budget, to account for unexpected expenses or price fluctuations that may arise during project implementation.

A well-prepared budget increases the funders' confidence in the applicant's capacity and the project's applicability and sustainability. The table below provides a detailed account of the structure of a project budget, using the Community Charcoal Energy Project as an example.

Table 1: Proposed budget for Community Charcoal Energy Project

SN	Item	Description	Amount in Tshs
1.	<i>Sensitisation and engagement of the community</i>	- Public meetings - Radio messages - Local consultation with government leaders	12,000,000
2.	<i>Training and capacity building</i>	- Workshop on charcoal making - Training in forest conservation - Training in gender inclusivity	15,000,000
3.	<i>Agroforestry</i>	Planting of trees in agricultural lands	20,000,000
4.	<i>Clean charcoal plant and technology</i>	Purchase of charcoal kilns and energy-efficient stoves	50,000,000
5.	<i>Establishment of community charcoal groups</i>	- Registration of members - Training of members	5,000,000
6.	<i>Coordination and project staff</i>	- Project officer - Field officers - Facilitators - Village leaders	12,000,000
7.	<i>M & E</i>	- Baseline and endline surveys - Field visits	6,000,000
8.	<i>Administrative and operational costs</i>	Transport, communication, internet, logistics	5,000,000
9.	<i>Language editing and translation</i>	Editing of the final report and translation into Kiswahili	6,000,000
10.	<i>Overhead costs 5%</i>	Unexpected expenses and price fluctuation	6,550,000
Total			137,550,000

**Activity 6.2**

Your school is experiencing a lack of dormitory space; therefore, write a project proposal to construct two dormitories, each capable of accommodating 80 students

**Activity 6.3**

Imagine that the project whose proposal you developed in **Activity 6.2** has now been completed. Write a comprehensive project report based on that project. The report should present what you planned, what you did during implementation, the results achieved, and your reflections on the overall process and outcomes of the project.

Use the structure and hints provided below to guide your writing. Your report should be clear, well-organised, and factual.

1. Title Page

Hint:

- i) Write the full title of your project (it should be clear and specific).
- ii) Include your name, class, school, date, and subject/course.

Example:

Title: Establishing a School Vegetable Garden

Name: Neema A. Joseph

Class: Form Six

School: Green Valley Secondary School

Date: July 2025

2. Acknowledgements

Hint:

- i) Thank the people or institutions who helped you complete the project.
- ii) Use polite and formal language to express appreciation.

Example:

I would like to thank my teacher, Mr John, for his guidance throughout this project. I would as well like to thank my classmates for their cooperation during the implementation of the project.

3. Executive Summary / Abstract

Hint:

- i) Summarise the whole report in one short paragraph (about 100–150 words).
- ii) Include the project's purpose, activities, main findings, and recommendations.
- iii) Write the executive summary after finishing writing the whole report.

4. Introduction

Hint:

- i) Explain the background or reason for your project.
- ii) State the project's objectives and importance.
- iii) Mention where and when it was carried out.

Example:

Start your introduction with a strong statement or hook (e.g., statistics, a relevant quotation, a question, or a brief story). Then explain how the statement relates to the report you are writing. Provide evidence and elaborate on it. Next, state the objectives of the project (e.g., This project aimed to reduce food costs at our school by starting a vegetable garden behind the laboratory block). Finally, indicate the timing of the project (e.g., It was carried out from March to June 2025).

5. Methodology / Project implementation

Hint:

- i) Describe how you carried out the project step by step.
- ii) Mention the materials, equipment, or resources you used.
- iii) Include challenges faced and how you solved them.

Example subheadings:

- i) Activities done
- ii) Materials and equipment used
- iii) Problems encountered

6. Results / Findings

Hint:

- i) Present what you achieved or discovered.
- ii) Use tables, figures, or photographs to illustrate some points.
- iii) Compare the results with your original objectives.

Example:

The project resulted in a successful harvest of 50 kg of spinach and 30 kg of tomatoes.

7. Discussion

Hint:

- i) Explain what your results mean.
- ii) Describe what went well and what could be improved.
- iii) Show lessons learned from doing the project.

8. Conclusion

Hint:

- i) Summarise the main achievements of your project.
- ii) State whether your objectives were met.

9. Recommendations

Hint:

- i) Suggest practical ways to improve or expand the project.
- ii) Advice on the need to implement similar projects in the future.

10. References (if applicable)

Hint:

- i) List books, websites, or other sources you used.
- ii) Use any standard referencing style, such as APA, MLA, Harvard, or Chicago, to cite your sources.

APA's Example:

Booth, W. C., Colomb, G. G., & Williams, J. M. (2008). *The craft of research* (3rd ed.). University of Chicago Press.

**Exercise 6.1**

Write short notes on the following elements of a project proposal.

- (a) Title of the project
- (b) Executive summary
- (c) Problem statement
- (d) Rationale/justification
- (e) Vision and objectives
- (f) Expected benefits
- (g) Deliverable
- (h) Indicators of success
- (i) Implementation plan
- (j) Budget and cost plan
- (k) Sustainability plan
- (l) Monitoring and evaluation plan
- (m) Conclusion

**Revision questions**

1. Explain why a project proposal is important for securing project funding.
2. With examples, explain how background to the problem effectively prepares a reader to understand the proposed project.
3. Discuss how persuasive writing is key in project proposal writing.
4. Create an imaginary project idea to address a current youth challenge, and outline the problem, rationale, and indicators of success.
5. A proposal reflects the writer's mindset more than the project itself. Discuss this statement with examples.
6. Discuss how writing a project proposal can shape your communication skills and attitude.

Using ICT for research and referencing

Introduction

In today's digital age, ICT facilitates access to academic information from reliable online sources, including e-books, journal articles, reports, images, and illustrations. However, using such online academic information responsibly requires due acknowledgement. In this chapter, you will learn how to search for online educational information, cite the sources consulted, generate reference lists, and produce well-referenced academic essays. The competencies developed will help you maintain accuracy, transparency, and integrity in academic writing.



Think

How to improve the quality of your academic work

Conducting online interviews to collect information

An online research interview is a structured conversation conducted between an interviewee and an interviewer who are not in the same physical location. This interview mode uses digital communication tools, such as video calls, phone calls, and text-based chats. They can be conducted in real time (synchronous) or recorded for later use (asynchronous). Synchronous interviews involve both parties meeting simultaneously via an internet conferencing platform or by phone. In contrast, in asynchronous interviews, respondents record their responses to preset questions and submit them at their convenience. The following are some of the reasons to conduct online research interviews:

- (a) To gather first-hand information from people with knowledge or experience about a topic
- (b) To reach out to people who can be hard to meet physically
- (c) To collect qualitative data (opinions, experiences, and attitudes)
- (d) To support written assignments, reports, or projects
- (e) It is easy to record and store information for later use



Activity 7.1

1. Search online for the following categories of ICT tools that can be used to conduct online interviews: video conferencing tools, messaging apps, email and online forms. For each category, answer the following questions:

- (a) Which tool is the easiest to use and why?
 - (b) Which tool is the most suitable for formal interviews and why?
 - (c) What challenges might arise when using these tools for interviews?
2. Write a short paragraph reflecting on the following:
- (a) What you learned about ICT tools for online interviews
 - (b) Which tool or category do you personally prefer? Give reasons.
 - (c) How can these tools improve communication in academic or professional settings?

Preparing for an online interview

Good preparation is essential for a successful online interview. To collect reliable online data, one must plan carefully, ask clear questions, and communicate politely and professionally. A good interview is one in which the researcher collects valuable data (evidence) to address a specific research problem. You should observe the following steps to conduct a good online interview:

- (a) Identify your topic of investigation: A subject of the inquiry states what is going to be studied. You need to read extensively to decide on the research topic.
- (b) Identify research objectives: The researcher develops objectives, states research questions, and determines data-collection methods, including online interviews.
- (c) Identify interview respondents: Interview respondents are called interviewees. These are usually selected based on their knowledge of the topic under investigation and their willingness to participate in interviews.
- (d) Prepare interview questions: You need to prepare an interview guide, which is a set of questions to be answered during online interviews. Depending on the nature of the study, you can use either open-ended questions or closed-ended questions to obtain data.
- (e) Choose a suitable online platform – one that both you and your interviewee can easily access.
- (f) Test your equipment (devices): Check your internet connection, microphone, camera, and any other devices you will use during the interview. Fix any dysfunction before the online interview begins.
- (g) Seek permission and schedule the interview: Be polite when reminding the respondent and confirm the interview time and date in advance.

Conducting the interview

Do the following when conducting the interview:

- (a) Begin politely by introducing yourself and the purpose of your study.
- (b) Ask for their permission to start the interview. Should you need to record the interview, obtain the respondent's consent before starting.

- (c) Use your interview guide to ask clear questions (open-ended or closed-ended) and take notes in a notebook.
- (d) Appreciation: Thank the respondent at the end of the interview. For example, “We have come to the end of this interview. Thank you for your time and for your shared views. I might call you another time in case I need clarification.”

This image depicts an online interview in progress. It highlights how interviews can be conducted professionally via video calls, regardless of location. Overall, it demonstrates how technology facilitates communication.



Figure 7.1 Interviewer and interviewee in an interview session

Neema: Good afternoon, sir.

Respondent: Good afternoon.

Neema: As I mentioned earlier over the phone, I am Neema Pesambili, a Form Six student at Sakasaka High School.

Respondent: Yes, Neema! How can I help you this time?

Neema: I'm conducting a small-scale study to determine which ICT tools are used in teaching. I am requesting your participation in my research (research title). I would appreciate it if you could spare a few minutes to answer a couple of questions.

Respondent: Yes, go ahead.

Neema: I'm sorry, sir! May I record this conversation on my audio recorder for use in case I miss some information? It will be used for this research only and not elsewhere.

Respondent: Sure, please go ahead.

- Neema:** Thanks. Which ICT tools do you always use in teaching?
- Respondent:** I prefer using my laptop, the theatre's display screen, a projector, a laser pointer, and a PA system.
- Neema:** [notes down the responses] Thank you, what do you mean by a PA system?"
- Respondent:** The PA system stands for the Public Address system.
- Neema:** What is it?
- Respondent:** It's an electronic sound amplification setup used to make a voice loud enough for a large audience to hear clearly.
- Neema:** Okay...may I know its components?
- Respondent:** Microphones, mixers or amplifiers, and loudspeakers.
- Neema:** Thank you very much for your answers.
- Respondent:** You are welcome.
- Neema:** I appreciate your cooperation. Bye for now.
- Respondent:** It is my pleasure.

Reflecting on the process

After the interview, reflect on your experience:

- What went well during the interview?
- What challenges did you face (e.g., poor connection, unclear answers)?
- How can you improve next time?

Finally, write a short paragraph summarising what you learned from the interview and the data you collected.



Activity 7.2

- Select a topic of study and then do the following:
 - Prepare an interview guide with both open-ended and closed-ended questions on a chosen topic (e.g., "*The effects of social media on students' performance*").
 - Conduct a short mock interview with your fellow using your phones or a classroom simulation.
 - Take notes of key points discussed.
 - Write a short paragraph describing the experience.
- Conduct a short online interview with someone about an academic topic of your choice. Write a brief report, including:

- (a) The purpose of the interview and the method used
- (b) Interview guide questions
- (c) A summary of the key points
- (d) What you learned from the process

Assessing the importance of basic online databases in learning

Reflect on the following:

- (a) A place where you usually store your notes, assignments, or research materials
- (b) Searching for information in a library catalogue or online database

A database is an organised collection of information that can be accessed, searched, and managed efficiently. Databases help students quickly find relevant, accurate, and up-to-date information. It plays a crucial role in assisting students to access, organise, and use information efficiently. Different types of databases provide reliable and relevant resources for research, assignments, and independent learning. Understanding the importance of these databases enables students to locate information quickly, make informed decisions, and enhance the quality of their learning.

Types of basic online databases for learning

Basic online databases used for learning fall under different categories depending on the context of use. The major types of databases are presented hereunder.

- (a) Library databases – Collect information about digital or online catalogues of books, e-journal papers, periodicals, reports, policies, regulations, etc.
- (b) Educational databases – Refer to a collection of information from online sources, such as Khan Academy, Coursera, and Google Scholar.
- (c) School databases – Have slimmer domains. These databases host student records, class notes, and exam results.
- (d) Subject-specific databases – A collection of engines used to search for information concerning a particular area of study. These include PubMed for science courses and JSTOR for humanities disciplines.

Importance of databases in learning

- (a) Databases provide quick access to reliable information; for instance, learners and teachers can access them. They can also quickly access definitions and descriptions for a phenomenon.
- (b) They organise learning resources: Databases help students and teachers gather the resources needed for a given study. When used properly, these databases can organize learning resources effectively. One can download online educational resources to teach and learn about specific concepts.

- (c) They support research and assignments: One key role of online databases is supporting research and assignments. Students conducting research must use these online databases to answer specific questions.
- (d) They encourage independent learning and critical thinking: Online databases save precious time and resources that could otherwise be invested in individual research. This means that they are tools for conducting research.



Exercise 7.1

1. Explain what database type you can use for a personal learning task (e.g., research, exam revision).
2. Write a short paragraph explaining:
 - (a) The type of database
 - (b) The information it provides
 - (c) How will it help you in learning

Citing and referencing

Citing means acknowledging the contributions from other authors and researchers whose ideas, arguments, and claims were used when writing an essay or research. Referencing means listing down in alphabetical order information about all sources (books, journal papers, book chapters, reports, etc.) used in writing essays or research reports. In academic writing, citing and referencing are crucial. Writing citations and references in academic writing signifies accuracy, transparency, integrity, and credibility of the essay or research report. By citing your sources, you demonstrate your engagement with existing research, acknowledge the intellectual property of other researchers, and allow readers to verify the information you present. You must declare to the reader the sources of knowledge, data, opinions, and arguments in your essay. Acknowledging sources is important because it shows how your arguments align with or depart from those of other sources. The essay below illustrates how the writer cites sources.

A **morpheme** is the smallest unit of a word that carries meaning (O'Grady, 1997). Unlike phonemes—which are meaningless speech sounds—morphemes contribute semantic content to the words they form. Yule (2010, p. 67) points out that morphemes also perform grammatical functions, indicating “past tense or plural”.

In English, morphemes can stand as whole words, like *computer*, or as meaningful sub-parts of words, such as the plural *-s* in *computers*. Fromkin et al. (2003) point out that morphemes are the essential building blocks of morphology since they enable speakers to construct complex words from simpler, meaningful elements.

There are two primary forms of morphemes, namely free morphemes and bound morphemes (O'Grady, 1997; Yule, 2010; Fromkin et al., 2003). **Free morphemes** are whole words such as *boy*, *girl*, *road*, and *river*. Conversely, **bound morphemes** need to be attached to other morphemes. Examples of bound morphemes are *post-* (meaning *after*) as in *post-independence*, *un* (meaning *not*) as in *unkind*, *-ness* (nominalising affix) as in *happiness*, and *-ed* (meaning past tense) as in *walked*.

Bound morphemes are further classified as inflectional or derivational. Inflectional morphemes mark grammatical categories without altering words' core meanings or word classes, as seen in the plural marker *-s* in *trees* or past tense *-ed* as in *jumped* (Katamba, 1993). In contrast, derivational morphemes create new words or grammatical categories. For example, the derivational morpheme *-ness* converts adjectives such as *happy*, *kind*, and *sad* into nouns: *happiness*, *kindness*, and *sadness*. It is worth noting that this distinction is central to understanding how English speakers structure and interpret words.

References

- Fromkin, V., Rodman, R., & Hyams, N. (2003). *An introduction to language* (7th ed.). Thomson Wadsworth.
- Katamba, F. (1993). *Morphology*. Macmillan Education.
- O'Grady, W., Dobrovolsky, M., & Katamba, F. (Eds.). (1997). *Contemporary linguistics*. St. Martin's Press.
- Yule, G. (2010). *The study of language* (4th ed.). Cambridge University Press.

In the above academic essay, the writer has cited four sources: Fromkin et al. (2003), Katamba (1993), O'Grady et al. (1997), and Yule (2010). The writer has also provided a list of references consulted in writing the essay.

Citing always adds value to a new work, as it demonstrates that what is written was once shared. It helps avoid plagiarism and outright rejection of essays. Citing sources is a sign of academic maturity; you acknowledge openly that you have used ideas from other sources rather than using them as if they were yours.

Why proper citation and referencing are important

Proper citation and referencing help to avoid plagiarism, maintain academic integrity, and provide a clear record of sources used in writing an essay or research report.

- (a) Citation and referencing help to avoid plagiarism by giving credit to the original authors of the ideas and information used in the research.
- (b) Proper citation and referencing maintain the academic integrity of the research by ensuring that the sources are accurately credited and the information is not misused.
- (c) Citation and referencing provide a clear record of the sources used in the research, making it easier for readers to locate and verify the information.

Citation and referencing styles

Several citation styles are recognised and used in academic writing. Each has its specific formatting guidelines. The most common styles are:

- (a) American Psychological Association (APA) style: This style is widely used in the social sciences, education, and psychology.
- (b) Modern Language Association (MLA) style: This style is dominant in literature, language studies, and the humanities.
- (c) Chicago Manual of Style (Chicago Style): This is a flexible style with variations used across fields such as history, the humanities, and law.

Citing sources and writing references

Writers must acknowledge ideas, views, theoretical models, and arguments or claims from other sources. They recognise other sources by citing the sources consulted. Citing different sources is done within the essay, known as in-text citation. There are two common ways to cite in-text.

One way is to write the surname and year of publication in brackets following the argument presented. An instance of this in-text citation is given below:

“Inflectional morphemes mark grammatical categories without altering a word’s core meaning or word class, as seen in the plural marker *-s* in *trees* or past tense *-ed* in *jumped* (Katamba, 1993).”

In the excerpt above, the writer acknowledges that the view and examples presented are from Katamba (1993). In this citing style, the surname and the year of publication of the source are written in brackets separated by a comma. Different from the above, another style of in-text citation is shown below:

“O’Grady et al. (1997) point out that morphemes are the essential building blocks of morphology since they enable speakers to construct complex words from simpler, meaningful elements.”

In the excerpt above, the writer acknowledges O’Grady et al. (1997). The surnames are part of the sentences, and only the year of publication is written in brackets.

References

These are sources writers consult when writing their essays. Usually, the references are listed alphabetically at the end of the essay after the conclusion paragraph/section. At the end of the three-paragraph essay presented earlier, the writer provided the reference list after the last paragraph. The following is an example of APA 7th edition style.

Fromkin, V., Rodman, R., & Hyams, N. (2003). *An introduction to language* (7th ed.). Thomson Wadsworth.

Katamba, F. (1993). *Morphology*. Macmillan Education.

O'Grady, W., Dobrovolsky, M., & Katamba, F. (Eds.). (1997). *Contemporary linguistics*. St. Martin's Press.

Yule, G. (2010). *The study of language* (4th ed.). Cambridge University Press.



Activity 7.3

Use the internet or your library to find examples of the recent versions of APA, MLA, and Chicago citation styles. For each style, identify how in-text citations are formatted and how reference entries (or bibliography/works cited) are formatted. Then, create a simple table as shown below:

Citation style	In-text citation example	Reference/bibliography example	Comment(s)
APA			
MLA			
Chicago			

Online citation and reference management systems

Online citation and reference management systems are web-based platforms that help students, researchers, and professionals collect, store, organise, and cite bibliographic information efficiently with minimal errors. Once writers have installed citation and reference software, they can import citation data directly into their Word documents from databases, library catalogues, and websites, automatically generating metadata such as authors, titles, and publication years. Because they operate online, users can access their libraries from multiple devices and synchronise their reference collections across locations. Examples of widely used online citation and reference management systems are Zotero, Mendeley, and EndNote Web. All these offer browser extensions for one-click citation capture, collaborative group libraries, and cloud-based storage. These tools streamline the research process by allowing users to manage large volumes of sources and maintain citation accuracy.



Revision questions

1. Discuss the role of ICT in accessing academic information in today's digital age.
2. Explain why proper citation and referencing are essential for academic integrity.
3. Define plagiarism and analyse practical strategies students can use to avoid it in academic writing.
4. Differentiate between synchronous and asynchronous online interviews, giving one advantage of each.
5. Differentiate the key steps for preparing for a successful online interview.
6. Examine how preparing an interview guide enhances the quality of the data collected.
7. Analyse the ways online databases can encourage independent learning and critical thinking.

Preparing and delivering academic presentations

Introduction

Academic presentations are a central part of communication in both high school and college. They require careful planning, thorough research, clear organisation, and effective public-speaking skills. While the term 'academic presentation' can broadly refer to both written and oral reports, this chapter focuses primarily on oral presentations. In this chapter, you will learn how to prepare high-quality presentations using a variety of multimedia platforms, and visual support such as slides, smart class, images, charts, and videos, and how to deliver them confidently and professionally. You will also explore techniques for engaging an audience, structuring your ideas logically, and using technology to support your message. The competencies you develop will enable you to communicate information confidently and professionally across different settings, especially in academic environments where clear, well-supported presentations are essential.



Think

How thoughtful preparation and clear organisation lead to a compelling academic presentation

Academic presentation

An academic presentation is a structured format for sharing specialised information, research findings, or scholarly work. It often combines clear spoken explanations with multimedia resources, such as slides, images, charts, diagrams, audio, or short video clips. The purpose is not only to discuss a topic but also to help the audience understand it through logical organisation and supporting evidence.

The following image is a quick example of how multimedia can make a presentation more straightforward and memorable. Instead of merely describing the idea, the visual helps us see it immediately and connect the message to something concrete. As we go through it, note what the picture highlights, because that is the same power that multimedia brings to every key point.

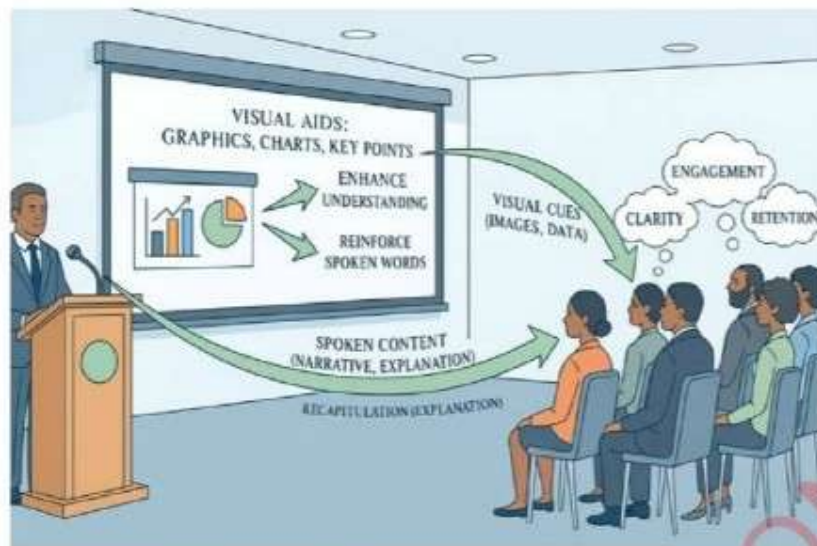


Figure 8.1: Enhanced presentation with multimedia



Exercise 8.1

Study the picture above and answer the following questions:

- What do the two primary arrows suggest about the interaction between the presenter, the visual aids, and the audience?
- What do you think would have been the consequence if the relationship between the visual aids and the audience was missing?
- Explain how the elements of clarity, engagement, and retention affect oral presentation.

An effective oral presentation is a dynamic, simultaneous blend of several components. These include the *spoken content* (narratives), *visual aids* (multimedia resources), and *non-verbal communication* (delivery). The audience, therefore, receives information both visually and verbally, leading to greater learning and memory.



Exercise 8.2

Write short notes on the essential components of an effective oral presentation.

Purposes of academic oral presentations

Academic oral presentations serve different purposes, depending on the topic and audience. They may be prepared to inform by explaining ideas or processes clearly, to persuade by convincing the audience to accept a viewpoint or take action, and to analyse by interpreting information such as results, patterns, or trends in data. Oral presentations also help learners demonstrate their understanding of a subject by organising and explaining key concepts in their own words. In addition, they are commonly used to report findings from investigations, experiments, surveys, or school projects in a clear, academic manner.



Activity 8.1

Use online or offline resources, including school library materials, textbooks, recorded speeches, TED Talks, class/webinar presentations, or educational documentaries, to locate academic presentations on various topics. Then, select ten (10) presentations and compile a short report for each one. Your report should be structured to address the following:

1. The purpose (What is the purpose of the report? Is it...)
 - a) To inform (e.g., explaining a scientific process)
 - b) To persuade (e.g., advocating for environmental action)
 - c) To analyse (e.g., presenting and interpreting data trends)
 - d) To demonstrate understanding of a topic (e.g., explaining a concept learned in class)
 - e) To report findings from research or projects (e.g., presenting results and conclusions)
2. Presentation effectiveness: For each report, briefly evaluate the presentation by focusing on the following key components:
 - a) Structure (introduction, transition between main points)
 - b) Visual aids (do they enhance or distract the spoken word?)
 - c) Delivery (speaker's engagement level through eye contact, energy, and pace)

Your report should follow the following structure:

Presentation title/topic: ...

Resource used (e.g., YouTube, TED Talk, Class/webinar Video): ...

Main purpose (Choose one from the list): ...

Justification for purpose: ...

Effectiveness of visual aids (Brief comment): ...

Planning the presentation

Planning an effective academic presentation begins with understanding the assignment clearly and preparing the content logically and evidence based. You should first identify the topic and focus and confirm the required length and time limit. Consider the audience and the presentation format - individual or group. Identify the appropriate multimedia platform (software) you will use (e.g., Google Slides, Canva). Crucially, you must also confirm the availability and functionality of all the necessary multimedia devices or support hardware (e.g., the projector, large monitor, speakers, laptop, and connection cables). Once all these are considered, you can conduct purposeful research using credible sources such as textbooks, academic journals, and reputable websites, while evaluating reliability and organising notes by theme. When searching, seek strong and appropriate visual aids for

your chosen platform to reinforce your message. Finally, a well-structured outline brings everything together - starting with an engaging introduction (hook, background, and thesis), developing 2–4 well-supported body points, and ending with a conclusion that summarises key ideas and offers implications or recommendations.

Multimedia platform and Visual support: Design and selection

A multimedia platform is a specialised software environment meant to design, organise, and manage information. Different platforms continue to evolve, while others eventually fall out of favour due to technological advancements. Common platforms for academic presentations include *Microsoft PowerPoint*, *Google Slides*, and *Canva*, each with tools tailored to different presentation needs. Multimedia tools are features or functions that transform a basic slide into an engaging visual presentation. They are in three main categories - visual and graphic tools (*chart & graph generators, image editing filters, photo/video integration features*), interactive and motion tools (*for transitions, object animation, interactive linking*), collaboration and organisation tools (*for real-time collaboration, commenting and feedback, slide mastering, template editing*). Visual support refers to any non-text element, such as a diagram, image, chart, or video, intentionally used to enhance or clarify the speaker's message. For the audience, they improve comprehension and memory retention.

Designing visual support, whether through slides, videos, or physical media, is about supporting your message, not competing with it. Compelling visuals make ideas clearer, keep the audience engaged, and help the presenter stay organised. To achieve this, you must strategically choose the proper presentation platform that aligns with your needs. Different platforms offer distinct strengths, including real-time collaboration and advanced data visualisation. Select one that aligns with your purpose, audience, and available resources.



Activity 8.2

Choose any topic and create a one-page outline for a presentation, including your platform choice and proposed visual support. Then, explain why each visual element strengthens your message.

Key considerations for creating visual supports and multimedia slides

Good images and slides help your audience quickly understand your message. Slides are meant to support the speaker, not replace them. The best slides are clear, neat, and easy to read from the back of the room. The key considerations of slide design include the following:

Simplicity

Keep slides clean and focused on the main idea. To achieve this, use minimal text (apply the *Rule of Six*). Use up to 6 words per line and up to 6 lines per slide. Write keywords, not complete sentences. Save detailed explanations for what you say while presenting. Do not crowd a slide with too many pictures, shapes, or paragraphs. Use blank space (also called *white space*) to make the slide feel organised and keep only what supports the slide's topic.

Consistency

Use the same style throughout the presentation to make it look professional and easier to follow. Use one theme or colour palette. Choose 2–3 primary colours and stick to them. Avoid changing background styles on every slide. Use the same font style for titles and body. Use one font for titles and one for body text (or use a single font for everything). Avoid fancy fonts that are hard to read. Align text and visuals properly. Keep titles in the same position on every slide. Align images and text neatly using gridlines or alignment tools. Ensure the spacing between elements is uniform.

Readability

Make sure the audience can easily see and understand your content. Use high contrast colours. Dark text on a light background is good, or light text on a dark background. Light text on a light background is bad, or colours that blend. Use the correct font size. For titles, 32 - 40 points is acceptable; for body text, 24–28 points. If you must shrink the font to fit, you probably have too much text. Test your slides in “Presenter View” or project them to assess whether they are legible from a distance.

Visual appeal

Visual appeal makes slides more interesting and helps the audience remember key ideas. Use images to show examples, places, people, or real situations; icons to represent ideas quickly (e.g., a recycling icon for the environment); charts to show numbers and comparisons clearly; and infographics to combine visuals and short text to explain a topic fast. These media should be high-quality and include clear, high-resolution images. For example, Microsoft PowerPoint provides options for inserting shapes, icons, and images on a slide. The platform also includes an AI-powered feature, ‘Design suggestions’, that automatically provides professional-looking slide layouts, colour schemes, and graphic ideas based on your content (text, images, lists) to make presentations visually appealing and engaging. This feature is available on the Design or Home tab. This feature works when a device is connected to the internet. However, avoid distracting animations and excessive transitions, as they can annoy the audience unless required by the nature of the presentation.

Using visual aids effectively

Visual aids help explain ideas more quickly than text alone, particularly when used correctly. Charts and graphs are used to represent data. Use bar charts for comparisons, line graphs for change over time, and pie charts for simple parts of a whole. Label axes and keep the chart simple. Photos are used to show real-world context. Use clear images that directly relate to the topic, such as a photo of soil erosion when discussing environmental degradation. Diagrams are better for showing processes. Diagrams are effective for step-by-step systems such as the water cycle, the digestive system, and the flow of electricity in a circuit. Use videos only to show something hard to explain with pictures. Keep clips brief to maintain audience attention. Short video clips are better for demonstrations (limit to < 30 seconds). Instead of embedding a video in your slides, you can add a link to the original site and open it during your presentation, provided the video is available online. Always test the video/link before presenting.

(a) Microsoft PowerPoint

Microsoft PowerPoint is a widely used tool for creating presentations for academic and professional purposes. It works reliably offline and supports features such as animations, charts, audio/video, and the ability to add notes (additional information) that you can glance at while presenting. Its simple presentation tools make it ideal for classrooms, meetings, and other academic settings. For example, to access Microsoft PowerPoint, you can open it as a desktop app from your computer's Start menu (Windows) or Applications folder (Mac) or use it online by visiting Office.com and signing in with your Microsoft account, and then selecting PowerPoint. You can also access it through the Microsoft 365 mobile app on Android/iOS, which provides enhanced functionality to help you design a well-structured, visually engaging presentation.



Figure 8.2: Image of the Microsoft PowerPoint programme



Activity 8.3

Prepare Microsoft PowerPoint slides on a topic of your choice that requires you to present complex, precise data through visual aids such as charts, graphs, or tables.

(b) Google Slides

Google Slides is ideal for teamwork and online collaboration because multiple people can work on the same presentation simultaneously. It automatically saves the work to Google Drive, reducing the risk of loss and simplifying access from anywhere. Sharing is simple — you can send a link and control whether others can view, comment, or edit. It also works smoothly across laptops, tablets, and phones, which is helpful when presenting or editing on different devices. To access Google Slides, open a web browser and go to slides.google.com (or drive.google.com and click New, then Google Slides). Sign in with your

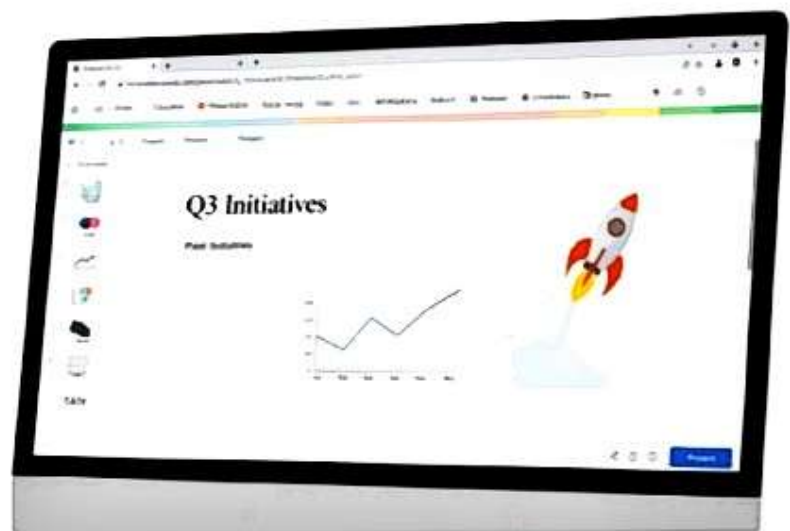


Figure 8.3: Image of the Google Slides programme

Google account, and then you can create a new presentation or open an existing one from Google Drive. You can also use the Google Slides mobile app by signing in and selecting a file.



Activity 8.4

Imagine that you are required to deliver a presentation on the theme: “Utilising Social Media as a Learning Platform”. Using Google Slides, prepare slides which briefly introduce your school and then explore how social media can be utilised as an educational tool.

(c) Canva

Canva is an online platform focused on creativity and modern design, offering a wide range of attractive templates, icons, and ready-made elements. Its simple drag-and-drop editor makes it easy to build polished, visually appealing presentations in minutes, even without design experience. You can also customise colours, fonts, and layouts to match your brand, and collaborate with others in real time. Overall, it is ideal for producing clean, professional-looking slides quickly and consistently.

To access Canva for designing presentation slides, open a browser and go to canva.com (or use the Canva app), then sign up or log in using your email, Google, or Facebook account. From the homepage, search for “Presentation” or select Create a design, then Presentation, choose a template or start with a blank design, and use Canva’s drag-and-drop editor to add and customise text, images, icons, and other elements. Once you are done, you can click Share to collaborate with others or download your slides in formats such as PDF or PowerPoint.

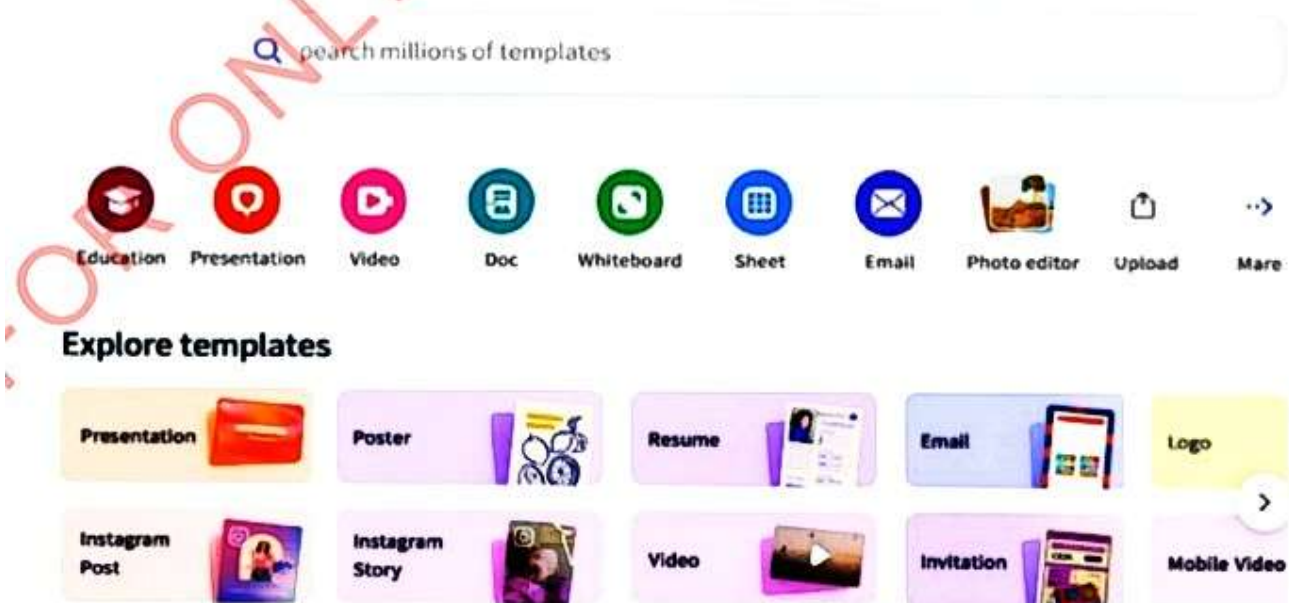


Figure 8.4: Image of the Canva programme



Activity 8.5

Create a short, visually appealing 4-slide presentation to raise students' awareness about a new debate club. Use design features (platform tools) available in Canva to create an impactful presentation.

Things to consider when using multimedia devices for presentation

Using multimedia devices in academic oral presentations can enhance effectiveness, engagement, and transparency. However, success depends on careful preparation and proper use of the devices. The following aspects should be considered when planning for an oral presentation using multimedia devices:

- i) **Check device compatibility:** Before your presentation, ensure that your hardware or support devices, such as a projector, laptop, or speaker system, are compatible with the presentation software you are using. Incompatibility between devices can cause delays or technical issues during your session. You should test all connections, including HDMI, VGA, and USB ports, to see that they are working. You should also regulate screen resolution and display settings to ensure clear visibility. Doing this beforehand ensures smooth flow and prevents interruptions during presentations. Remember to have backup batteries and adapters just in case.
- ii) **Ensure clear audio and visuals:** Quality visuals and sound are crucial for effective communication. Make sure that images, videos, and slides are clear and not distorted. Adjust the volume and clarity of audio clips so everyone in the room can hear comfortably. Poor visual or auditory quality can distract the audience, reducing concentration and comprehension. Lighting in the presentation venue should be well controlled, as neither excessively bright nor dim light is recommended. Lighting in the room should also be suitable to prevent glare on the screen.
- iii) **Keep content relevant and straightforward:** Multimedia device should support your message, not overwhelm the audience and make them emotional. Remember that the aim is for the audience to learn something and not to be obsessed. Hence, you must ensure that your content does not arouse emotions. Use concise slides, relevant and decent images, and short video clips. Avoid flashy images that might distract listeners, or overload slides with too much text or overly complex graphics. Each element in the content should reinforce your main points. Clear and focused content helps maintain audience attention and enhances understanding. Consider using bullet points and simple images or charts for clarity.
- iv) **Practice using multimedia platforms and devices:** Familiarity with both software and support devices boosts confidence and reduces mistakes. Rehearse your presentation while using all the equipment beforehand to ensure smooth transitions between slides,

videos, and audio. Practising helps you monitor your time and identify potential areas requiring further attention. It also helps users quickly learn how to adjust device settings when required. Knowing how to use presentation devices effectively makes your delivery more professional.

- v) **Have a backup plan:** Technical issues and unexpected faults can hinder your presentation at any time. Thus, you should always have a backup plan. Keep a copy of your presentation on a USB drive, in the cloud, or on another device. Prepare printed handouts or notes in case the multimedia device fails. Being ready for unexpected problems reduces stress and maintains professionalism. Inform yourself about alternative ways to present the material. This ensures that your audience still receives the intended information.
- vi) **Maintain audience engagement:** Use multimedia to capture and sustain audience attention. Incorporate visuals, animations, or short videos that relate directly to your topic. Avoid long, monotonous slides or continuous text reading. Engage your audience by asking questions or visually highlighting key points. Interactive elements, such as polls or quizzes, can also enhance participation. This approach makes your presentation more memorable and effective.
- vii) **Check the venue setup:** The physical setup of the presentation venue may affect how well the multimedia device works. Ensure that the screen or projector is visible to everyone and that seating arrangements do not obstruct the view. Ensure sufficient power outlets are available and avoid placing devices in direct sunlight, as this can affect screen visibility. Test the audio system to make sure it reaches all corners of the room with minimal echo. Proper room preparation helps prevent distraction. A well-arranged space improves audience comfort and attention.
- viii) **Manage time wisely:** Multimedia presentations can sometimes take longer than planned. Allocate time to each slide, video, or demonstration so that you do not exceed the allotted time for your presentation. Avoid spending excessive time on a single visual, as this may bore the audience. Practise pacing during rehearsals to ensure smooth delivery. Allow time for questions and discussions without rushing. Effective time management ensures that your presentation is professional and effective.
- ix) **Adopt a convenient seating plan:** Arrange your seating before starting the oral presentation. The seating plan should optimise audience interaction. You should keep in mind that the very placement of chairs and tables in a venue can shape the audience's ability to connect, collaborate, and network. Speakers can choose from several seating arrangements when planning for an oral presentation. These include theatre and auditorium styles, classroom setups, U-shaped arrangements, banquet styles, boardroom styles, hollow-square styles, and cabaret-style seating.

Guidelines for effective use of multimedia platforms in oral presentation

There are guidelines for the effective use of multimedia platforms. These divide the use of multimedia platforms into two: the use *before* and *during* oral presentations. The guidelines are presented hereunder.

Before the presentation

1. Define your objectives: Clearly state the specific objective(s) of your presentation. The objective(s) will guide your content selection.
2. Outline your content: Determine the structure of your presentation by arranging its key aspects in a logical flow and stick to this structure during oral presentation.
3. Select a template: Choose the most suitable template that supports your message and allows for easy integration of multimedia tools and visual support.
4. Assess the technical environment: Confirm the specifications of your venue. For example, if you are presenting in a smart classroom, ensure that your platform is compatible with the available multimedia devices (e.g., screen, projector, microphone, and speaker system).
5. Develop multimedia content: Add visuals, audio, or audiovisuals to illustrate your points and enhance audience understanding.
6. Add accompanying written content: Align the text (font type and size) to your audience's preferred font size for better visibility. Keep text on your slides concise and straightforward to avoid overwhelming your audience. Remember to use large fonts and add captivating effects, such as colour, bold face, and italics.
7. Review and practise: Thoroughly review your presentation to iron out any errors and practise to ensure smooth delivery and transitions between slides or points.

During the presentation

1. Supplement, do not replace: Use multimedia to enhance your oral message; do not let the media do the talking on your behalf.
2. Keep slides simple: Use high-quality images (high-resolution), graphics, and charts that are easy to understand at a glance. Ensure your audience shares the same understanding of the content of your slides.
3. Maintain visual cohesion: Stick to a consistent colour palette and avoid excessive animations or distracting effects.
4. Use audio wisely: Choose audio content that complements your visuals and narration, rather than competing with them or repeating.
5. Focus on key information: Present content in a logical way that expands on specific ideas, rather than tautologising themes and displaying lengthy sections of text.
6. Use transitions: Employ clear transitions to guide the audience smoothly from one point or concept to the next.

7. Speak clearly and concisely: Use short, simple sentences, speak at a moderate pace, and make eye contact with your audience.
8. Be confident and enthusiastic: Deliver your presentation with energy to capture and maintain audience attention.



Exercise 8.3

Explain the key components of a smart class and analyse how an integrated environment contributes to the successful delivery of oral academic presentations.

Presenting project proposals and project reports

Presentation of project proposals

A project proposal presentation should be clear, persuasive, and easy to follow, guiding the audience from the project rationale to the benefits likely to be received by the target community or organisation. In Chapter Six, it was emphasised that a well-prepared project proposal increases the chance of receiving funding or support. When adapting your written proposal for a multimedia platform, shift your focus from long paragraphs to powerful visual summaries. Remember to structure your presentation for impact and visualise the need. For official presentations, maintain professional cohesion (e.g., a professional slide template, an official colour scheme, and logo placement) to enhance credibility.



Activity 8.5

Create a short, visually appealing 4-slide presentation to raise students' awareness about a new debate club. Use design features (platform tools) available in Canva to create an impactful presentation.



Activity 8.6

Present the project proposal you prepared in **Activity 6.2** using multimedia.

Presentation of project reports

- A project report presentation should provide stakeholders with a clear, evidence-based update on the project's status, its achievements, the challenges affecting progress, and the decisions or support required next. As explained in Chapter Six, the presentation should always follow a simple, logical flow: set the context and overall status, show progress and results with supporting evidence, explain budget performance and key risks/issues, and conclude with lessons learned and a clear action plan for the next period. Converting a written project report into a digestible format for a multimedia presentation should be done carefully, using multimedia tools such as graphs to transform raw statistics into clear visual evidence, and icons and colour-coding to differentiate issues.

**Activity 8.7**

Present a project report you prepared in **Activity 6.3** using multimedia.

**Revision questions**

1. Define the term “Smart Class environment” and briefly outline its key technical components (hardware and software).
2. Explain how a presenter’s failure to assess the technical environment before the presentation could lead to poor outcomes in the presentation.
3. Explain the multimedia platforms and visual aids you would use to convert the following project report information:
 - (a) The raw financial data into an easily digestible visual.
 - (b) The list of completed tasks is included in a quick progress summary.
4. Discuss the importance of thorough preparation before an academic oral presentation.
5. Explain how simplicity, consistency, and readability enhance oral presentation through multimedia.

Interpreting and using visual representations

Introduction

In academic communication, words are not the only means of expressing ideas. Charts, tables, diagrams, and other illustrations are potent tools for presenting information clearly and concisely. In this chapter, you will learn to interpret such visuals by identifying their types, analysing their details, recognising patterns and trends, and explaining their significance in context. You will also learn how to use illustrations effectively to communicate information in academic settings. The competencies developed will enable you to understand visual representations and create them to convey meaning.



Think

Graphs, diagrams, and maps help the reader to understand ideas beyond the words

Illustrations in academic documents

In academic writing, we often include illustrations such as graphs, tables, diagrams, and maps to summarise information that is not readily apparent to a layperson. The details of illustrations can convey much of the content that would otherwise require many words in a paragraph. For example, the simple population graph below requires interpretation beyond the graph.

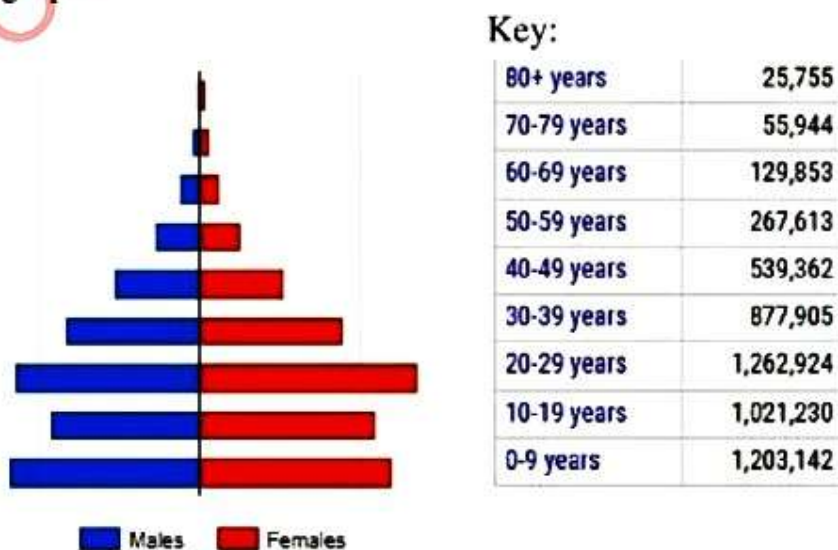


Figure 9.1: Population distribution by age and sex

The population distribution graph above reveals many details that are not written in words. The graph includes a key to help interpret its information. Although it appears simple, the image depicts real people living in a specific area, such as a village, district, region, or country. The graph groups people by sex, with males on the left in blue and females on the right in red. Each horizontal bar represents an age group, starting with children aged 0–9 at the bottom.

The graph shows nine bars representing the populations of children, adolescents (teenagers), adults, and older adults. Overall, the population is pyramidal, meaning that the number of people decreases with age. This situation explains why there are very few people aged 60 and above. It also suggests that, although many children are born, many die over the years, with deaths becoming more noticeable from around age 30.

The graph also highlights the size of different age groups. Children aged 0–9 form the second-largest group, with a population of 1,203,142, after the 20–29-year-old group, which is the largest. Even between these two groups, there are apparent gender differences: among children aged 0–9, males are the majority, while among people aged 20–29, females are the majority. The length of the bars shows this. At the bottom, the bar for males is longer than that of females, whereas in the 20–29 age group, the bar for females is longer than that for males.

Although this is a single population graph, it summarises substantial information in a single illustration. In fact, the data comes from the 2022 Population and Housing Census for the Dar es Salaam Region (Tanzania Bureau of Statistics, 2022), which you can consult for more details.

Interpreting illustrations in academic documents

Interpreting illustrations in academic documents is essential for fully understanding the research being presented. Visual elements such as graphs, diagrams, and tables often convey complex information more efficiently than text alone. The following six steps can help interpret illustrations thoroughly in academic communication, whether in writing or oral presentations.

Step 1: Identify the type of illustration

The first step is to identify the type of illustration you are looking at. Such types could be images, figures, maps, graphs, and drawings. All of these are intended to help the reader understand the text. Without a clear understanding of the illustration type, you can hardly make sense of what you are reading.

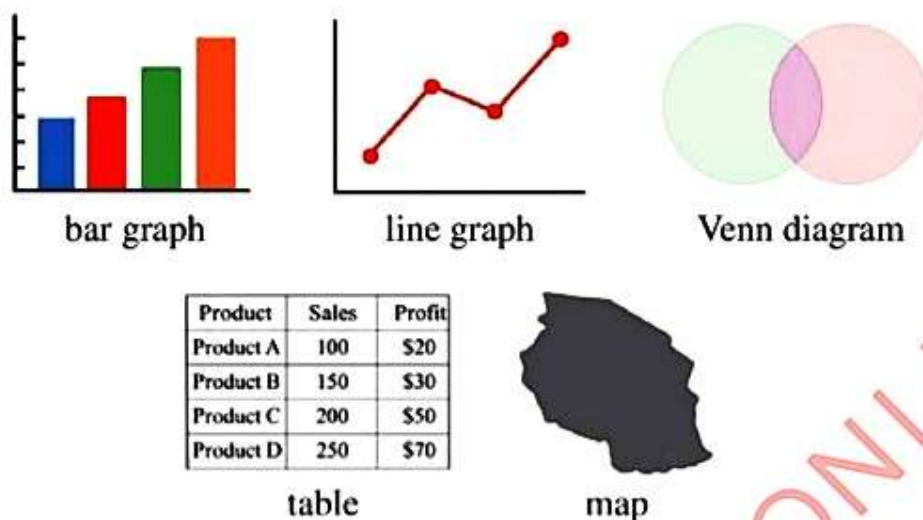


Figure 9.2: Illustrations used in academic writing

Different illustrations serve different purposes. Even illustrations that appear similar may serve different purposes depending on the nature of the material being read. As shown above,

- A bar graph compares quantities.
- A line graph shows change over time.
- A Venn diagram highlights similarities and differences.
- A map presents geographical distribution.
- A table organises detailed numerical data.



Activity 9.1

Use online or offline resources to locate an illustration, such as a chart, graph, infographic, map, or Venn diagram. Choose one that interests you and write a short explanation in two to three paragraphs, answering the following questions:

- What type of illustration is it?
- What information does it show?
- What patterns, trends, or key messages can you identify?
- Why do you think the creator chose this visual format?

Step 2: Read the title, labels, and keys

Titles and labels provide clues about the subject and variables being presented. In bar graphs, for instance, you always need to pay closer attention to axes, headings, captions, and keys because they carry important details for interpretation. Bar graphs consist of columns of bars, with labels beneath indicating, for instance, months of the year, temperature, and rainfall. Usually, bar graphs have two axes - the primary axis on the left and the secondary axis on the right. The vertical axes show units of measurement depicted in the graph. The

units provide evidence of the relationship between the primary and secondary axes. These are important skills in interpreting graphs. Maps, photographs, statistical information, drawings, and other visual cues might have benchmarks for interpretation. Figure 9.3 shows the average monthly rainfall and temperature in a specific area of Tanzania over five years.

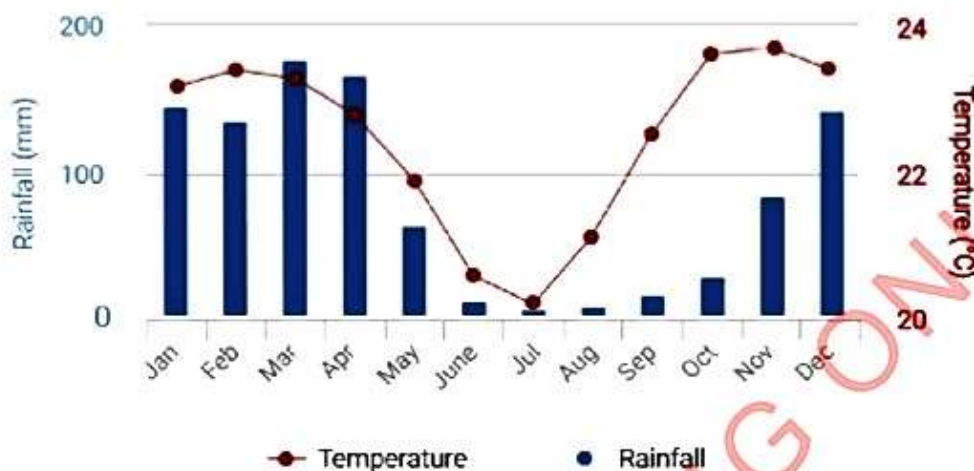


Figure 9.3: The average monthly rainfall and temperature over five years

The bar graph above shows the average annual temperatures and rainfall from January to December over five years. The graph also shows changing patterns of average temperature and rainfall across the months. It also shows the colder seasons (°C on the right axis) and the wetter seasons (mm on the left axis). All these details are available in the title, labels, and keys that are always provided. The same steps are used in subjects such as English, where a tree diagram would be titled “A tree diagram showing Mr Masudi’s family”. The names would accompany this and, probably, the years of birth of the family members. Thus, you can interpret the illustrations thoroughly by studying the provided titles, labels, and keys.



Activity 9.3

Use offline or online sources to find one illustration and study its title, labels, axes, and key/legend. Then, write a short paragraph by answering the following questions.

1. What is the title of the illustration, and what does it tell you?
2. What labels are shown, and what do they represent?
3. If there are axes, what units of measurement are used?
4. What information does the key/legend provide?
5. What pattern or trend do you see in the illustration?
6. How do the title, labels, and key help you understand the illustration?

Step 3: Observe details

This step involves paying attention to the details provided. You are supposed to examine all features in the illustration with an analytical eye. Colours are important components of interpretation. Find something of substance and objectively pay attention to what they

represent. In addition to colours, pay attention to axes, scales, legends, units, shapes, and arrows. These details guide the interpretation. For example, in a pie chart of household expenses, the colours in the legend may represent categories such as *food*, *rent*, *transport*, and *education*. Without looking at the legend, the chart would be meaningless and confusing. The following pie chart is worth considering:



Figure 9.4: Monthly household expenditure

As noted earlier, some visual images are colourful. Good examples are pie charts. However, the colouring is not for fancy. Colours in pie charts are deliberately used; your task is to make sense of them. They represent distinct budget categories, such as education, health care, food, savings, and housing (rent). Each sector is calculated as a percentage of the overall budget and represents a share of it. You can see that this family spends a larger part of its income (70%) on food, education, and health care. Rent and other charges share a similar percentage (12.5% each), while savings come last at 5%. More could be said about this pie chart, but the most important thing is to know that you must observe the details of the illustration to interpret the visual image objectively.

Step 4: Look for patterns or trends

Patterns are another significant milestone in the interpretation of illustrations. Consider patterns rather than focusing on individual points. You must search for general patterns in the image. Ask yourself: Is something increasing, decreasing, repeating, or contrasting? For example, in a line graph of student performance, a steadily rising line from left to right indicates an increase or growth. Consider the average annual rainfall and temperature graph of Tanzania shared earlier; the line and bars (from January to December) suggest rising and decreasing rainfall and temperature in some months. There is a significant decrease in rainfall and temperature in mid-year, followed by an increase toward the end of the year and the beginning of the new year; this pattern is observed. This information is essential for the reader and helps plan annual economic activities.

Step 5: Summarise the message

Condense the main point into one or two sentences. This forces you to focus on the essential meaning rather than every detail. For example, you can conclude or summarise the details of the pie chart shared earlier by saying, "The figure shows that the family spends more money on food, education, and health care; hence, the family has little to contribute to recreational activities and community development services." Generally, the specific phrases that academicians and researchers use to introduce and interpret these visuals include "The graph indicates that ...," "From the diagram, it is observed that ...," "The table highlights ...," and interpretive phrases like "This suggests that..." or "This implies that ...", which connect the visual evidence to the argument being made.

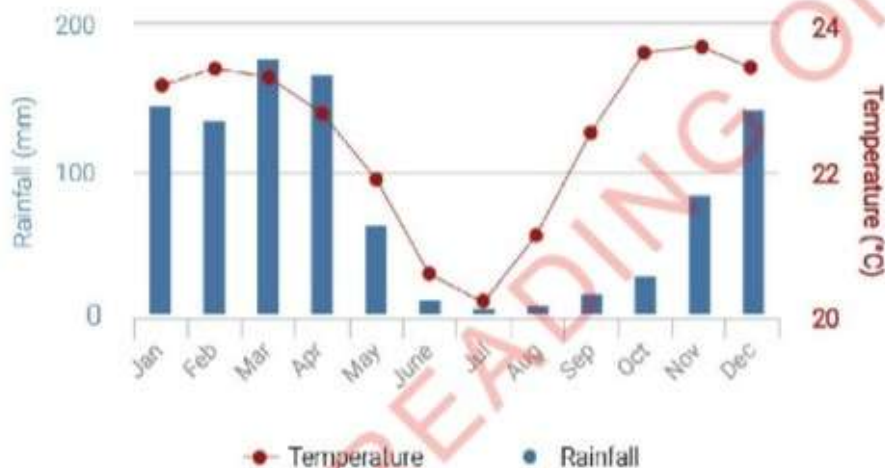
Step 6: Interpret its significance

Finally, explain why the illustration matters in the given context. Ask: “What does this tell us? How does it support the text or argument?” In the graph of average annual rainfall and temperature, several key points are worth noting. One important lesson is that graphs provide evidence to support decisions about economic activities, such as agriculture and pastoralism. The bar graph illustrates the effects of global warming: increases in both rainfall and temperature are clearly evident.

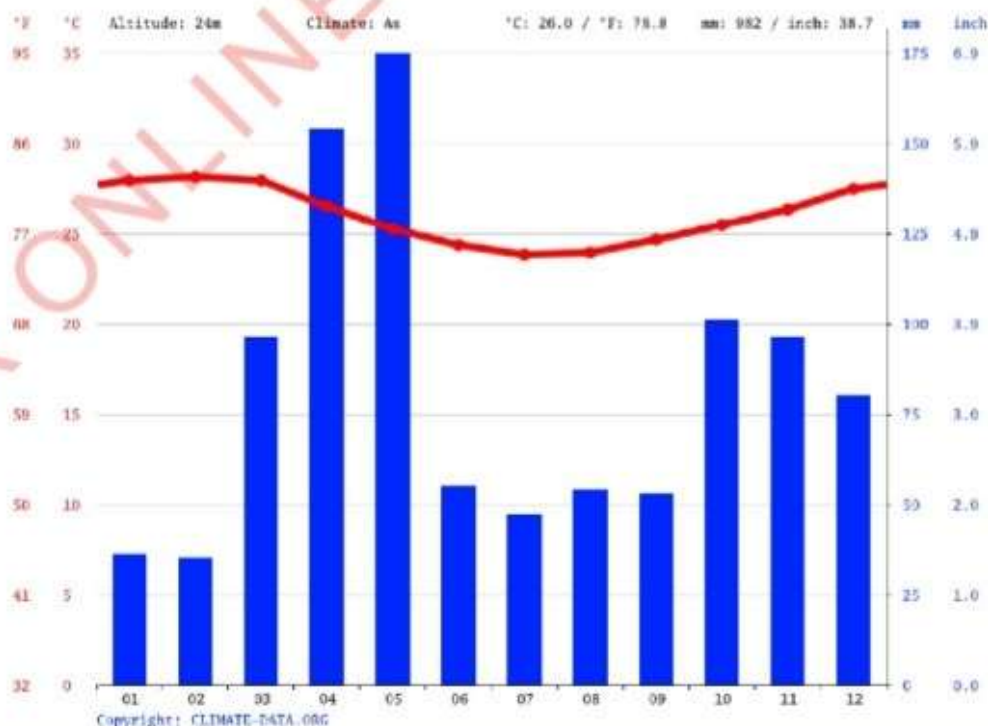


Exercise 9.1

- Study the following graph and write a summary of your interpretation.

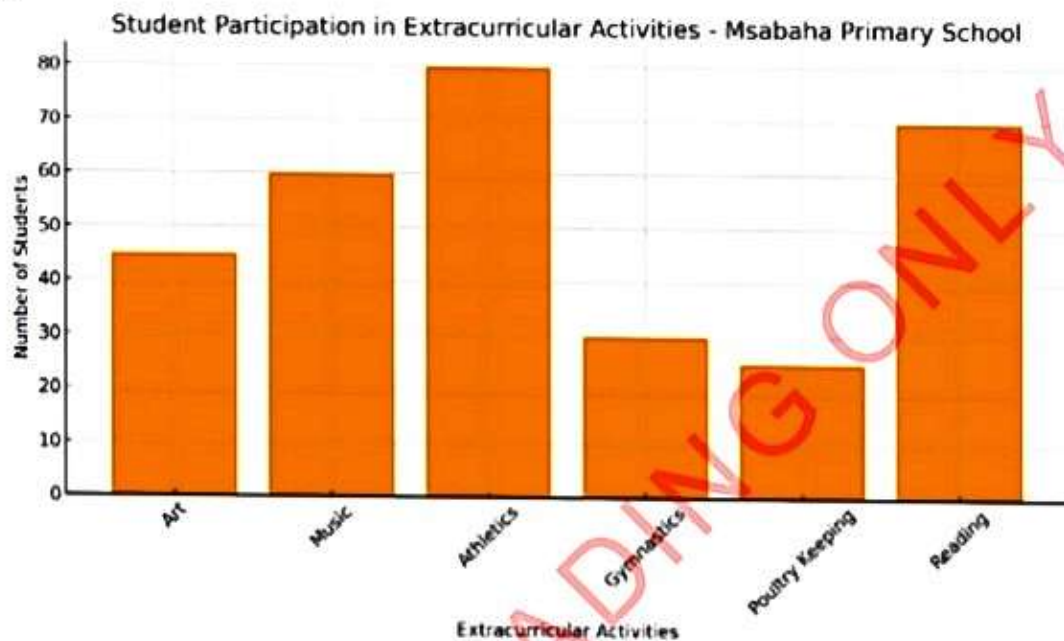


- Study the graph for the Tanga Region and answer the questions that follow.



- Which elements of climate are shown on the graph?
- Which element of climate details do the columns represent?
- Which element of climate does the line represent?

- (d) What information is depicted on the primary axis?
- (e) What is the significance of combining the two aspects in the graph?
3. Interpret the information on the following graph, presenting the number of students who participated in various extracurricular activities. Write a summary of your interpretation.



Using complex illustrations to prepare academic documents

When using illustrations, one should select the type that best conveys the information. For example, a bar graph for comparing values, a map for showing locations, or a table for arranging data in rows and columns. By carefully reading titles, labels, and keys, both writers and readers can use these visuals to communicate patterns, relationships, and main points more effectively than with words alone. Using illustrations correctly strengthens academic documents and supports more transparent communication.



Exercise 9.2

1. Use the data in the following table to create a bar graph showing the number of hours studied each day of the week.

S/N	Day	Hours studied
1.	Monday	2
2.	Tuesday	1
3.	Wednesday	3
4.	Thursday	2
5.	Friday	1
6.	Saturday	4
7.	Sunday	2

2. Present the number of students in each school club using either a bar graph or a pie chart.

Club	Number of Students
Science Club	45
Debate Club	30
Drama Club	20
Environmental Club	25
Sports Club	50

3. Using the provided data, create a line or bar graph showing monthly rainfall. Make sure that you include a title, labels, and units on the axes.

Month	Rainfall (mm)
January	35
February	28
March	40
April	70
May	85
June	95
July	120
August	110
September	80
October	60
November	45
December	30



Activity 9.2

Compile a comprehensive four-year report detailing your school's academic performance in the Form Six national examinations. Use visual representations, such as tables and graphs, to illustrate performance trends.



Revision questions

- Why are visual representations such as graphs, tables, and diagrams important in academic communication?
- Explain how visuals can help a reader understand ideas that may not be clear from text alone.
- Examine the types of illustrations commonly used in academic writing, and what purpose each type serves.

4. Analyse Figure 9.1: *Population distribution by age and sex*. What key information can be interpreted from the pyramidal shape of the population graph?
5. How do titles, labels, and keys/legends help in interpreting visual illustrations? Give an example.
6. Evaluate how patterns or trends in a visual can provide deeper insights compared to analysing isolated data points.
7. What mistakes do students commonly make when interpreting visuals, and how can these be avoided?
8. If you were creating your own illustration for an academic report, what factors would guide your choice between a bar graph, line graph, pie chart, map, or table?

OR ONLINE READING ONLY

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